

# BRINGING WORK HOME: FLEXIBLE WORK ARRANGEMENTS AS GATEWAY JOBS FOR WOMEN IN WEST BENGAL\*

LISA HO  
SUHANI JALOTA  
ANAHITA KARANDIKAR

There is a large latent workforce in developing countries that consists of hundreds of millions of women who prefer to have paid work and yet are out of the labor force. Often, available job opportunities are incompatible with traditional gender roles that encourage women to stay at home. In a randomized experiment with 1,670 households, we partner with a jobs platform to offer short-term data work to women who are out of the labor force. We find three main results. First, flexible work-from-home jobs are highly effective at bringing women into paid work. Job flexibility more than triples take-up from 15% for an office job to 48% for a job that women can do from home while multitasking with childcare. Second, these jobs can act as a stepping stone to less flexible work. Trying paid work from home increases take-up of less flexible jobs two to three months later among women without previous work experience. “Gateway jobs” are especially important for women from more traditional households: their labor supply is more likely to be marginal to flexibility, and in turn, work experience shifts their attitudes to become less traditional. Third, from the labor demand side, remote work comes with trade-offs in worker performance. Working from the office increases accuracy by 3% and speed by 18%. However, these performance drawbacks of work-from-home arrangements may be outweighed by the increase in available workers. *JEL codes:* C93, J16, J22, J24, J32, M54, O12, Z13.

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## I. INTRODUCTION

There is a large latent workforce in developing countries that consists of women who would prefer to work for pay and yet are out of the labor force. Representative surveys estimate that this latent labor force numbers in the hundreds of millions of women, largely concentrated in South Asia, the Middle East, and North Africa.<sup>1</sup> This untapped workforce has high-stakes consequences for both the well-being of women and girls and aggregate efficiency. In addition to respecting individual preferences, increasing the share of women in the labor force could improve outcomes such as agency, health, and educational attainment for women and girls (Duflo 2003; Jensen 2010; Afridi, Mukhopadhyay, and Sahoo 2016) and lead to a more efficient allocation of men's and women's labor that could contribute to economic development (Hsieh et al. 2019; Ashraf et al. 2024). This misallocation and, consequently, potential gains are particularly pronounced in countries such as India where levels of female employment are low despite advancements in women's education.

In these countries, social norms are thought to be a key barrier to women's paid work (Jayachandran 2021). One widespread norm in this context is that a woman's place is in the home. In India, many women spend limited time outside the home: the median working-age married woman spends just 0.5 hours per day outside her home, with 45% not leaving the home at all on an ordinary day (Andrew and Smurra 2024). This norm is in conflict with available jobs, few of which are fully remote.<sup>2</sup> This mismatch

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1. Based on a 2016 ILO–Gallup poll across 142 countries. In India alone, Agte and Bernhardt (2024) estimate that more than 100 million women are disallowed from working.

2. As far as we know, no representative survey in India exists; however, The Economic Times (<https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/jobs/hr-policies-trends/indian-tech-drives-faster-adoption-of-hybrid-work-mode/articleshow/112253169.cms?from=mdr>) reported that 20% of new job postings in summer 2024 were remote or hybrid.

between jobs that are available and jobs that women could do without violating norms of appropriate behavior suggests two potential strategies: (i) change norms so that existing jobs become more acceptable for women, or (ii) change jobs to be more compatible with existing norms. In this project, we start by taking the second approach: change jobs so women can do them while incurring lower norms-related costs. However, the two levers may be mutually reinforcing. If a woman's earned income and labor supply affect attitudes about women and work, then an approach that starts by changing jobs might in turn change gender norms.

In a randomized field experiment in West Bengal, we test the effects of offering an emerging type of work—digital gig work—that is relatively compatible with existing norms of women's behavior due to the ability to work from home at flexible hours. Our experiment is designed to speak to three main research questions. First, would offering at-home, flexible work arrangements increase female labor force participation, and if so, which dimensions of flexibility are important? Second, given that many existing jobs require in-person attendance, can women who are initially only able to work from home use flexible jobs as a stepping stone to jobs with less flexible work arrangements? Third, to understand whether employers have an incentive to introduce remote working arrangements, what are the effects of working from home on job performance for inframarginal workers and due to any change in the composition of workers drawn to the firm?

We randomly assign women from 1,670 lower-middle-income households to a treatment group that receives a job offer of month-long digital gig work or to a control group that receives no job offer. Among those receiving job offers, we introduce variation along three dimensions of flexibility: (i) the ability to change one's work time from day to day, (ii) the ability to combine work with child-care, and (iii) the ability to work from home. All jobs are part-time, last for one month, and are offered in partnership with a smartphone-based data tasks platform in India. To separate the effects of offering work-from-home arrangements on worker composition from effects on job performance, after participants have decided to accept or reject their initial job offer, we randomly select half of the participants in less flexible job groups to be surprised with an upgrade to the most flexible job (as in [Karlan and Zinman 2009](#)). After the jobs are completed, we estimate the effects of work experience on outcomes including women's gender attitudes and agency. Two to three months later, we measure take-up of new

work opportunities (jobs round 2), including the effects of the initial at-home work experience on take-up of less flexible jobs.

Most study participants are married women with little previous work experience. To focus on the extensive margin of labor force participation, women are only eligible for the study if they are not currently in the labor force or enrolled in skills training. During study recruitment, to avoid selecting the sample based on interest in finding paid work, potential participants are not told that the baseline survey could lead to a job opportunity. This leads to a sample where 69% have never worked for pay prior to the study. However, to ensure women have the skills necessary to do the job if assigned to it, they must be literate in Hindi or Bangla and have access to an Android smartphone. Husbands and parents-in-law play a large role in whether women work: only 36% of women report having the final say in their own labor supply decisions.

We find three main sets of results. First, flexible work arrangements more than triple women's job take-up. Compared to an office job, the most flexible job we offer—which includes the ability to choose work hours flexibly, combine work with childcare, and work from home—dramatically increases take-up from 15% to 48% ( $p < .001$ ). This 33 percentage point effect on women's job take-up is larger than effects of previously tested interventions to increase women's labor supply. For example, a generalized self-efficacy treatment increased women's job take-up by 32% (5 percentage points) in Uttar Pradesh (McKelway 2025), and correcting Saudi men's second-order beliefs about women working outside the home increased job sign ups by 36% (9 percentage points) (Bursztyn, González, and Yanagizawa-Drott 2020). The effect is also large relative to women's labor supply response to wages: in an experiment in Mumbai, increasing wages by nearly five times produced an increase in take-up only one-fifth the size (Jalota and Ho 2024).

To shed light on which mechanisms drive the effects of flexible work arrangements on women's labor supply, we randomly vary dimensions of flexibility across job offers. This variation allows us to separately estimate the contributions of having flexible work hours, combining work with childcare, and working from home to the overall effect of flexibility on job take-up. The ability to work from home, even without time flexibility or the ability to combine work with childcare, doubles take-up from 14.4% to 29.3% ( $p < .01$ ). The ability to multitask work with childcare is

also important, increasing job take-up by 57% to 68% ( $p < .01$ ), from 29.3% to 46.0% (without time flexibility), and from 28.6% to 48.0% (with time flexibility). The ability to choose work hours flexibly, however, does not significantly change take-up—these out-of-labor-force women can, and choose to, set aside consistent hours for paid work. Therefore, decomposing the 33 percentage points effect of bundled flexibility, approximately half (15 percentage points) comes from the ability to work from home and the other half (17–19 percentage points) from the ability to multitask work with childcare.

Second, we find that flexible work arrangements are not only effective at bringing out-of-labor-force women into paid work but can also act as a stepping stone to less flexible jobs. To test whether flexible work can act as a gateway job to less flexible work, we return to all study participants two to three months after the end-line survey and offer them another randomly assigned job. The jobs round 2 offers vary in flexibility along the same dimensions as the initial jobs and also introduce variation in the type of work offered; while the original jobs were all online gig work, second-round jobs also include non-digital piece-rate work (sewing masks or making jewellery) to assess if effects on interest in work operate through digital-specific mechanisms or apply to interest in paid work more broadly. Consistent with the initial work experience offering a low-cost opportunity to learn what it is like for women to earn income, women who had no work experience prior to the study are 9 percentage points more likely to start their randomly assigned round 2 job if they were first given the chance to experience a more flexible job during the initial intervention ( $p = .02$ ).

One mechanism consistent with this gateway-job effect is a mutually reinforcing relationship between gender attitudes supportive of women's paid work and women's actual labor supply, in which work experience shifts attitudes about appropriate behavior for women and consequently expands the set of jobs within reach. Women with more traditional attitudes at baseline had a stronger labor supply response to job flexibility, and in turn were also more likely to shift their gender attitudes in response to work experience. On average, women's gender attitudes became 0.06 standard deviations less traditional ( $p = .02$ ), with more traditional women's attitudes shifting by 0.11 standard deviations ( $p < .01$ ).

Turning to the labor demand side, the effects of flexibility on women's job participation show that introducing work-from-home even temporarily might allow employers to dramatically increase their pool of potential workers. So why do firms not offer flexible work arrangements more often? Beyond fixed costs and feasibility, employers may be concerned about how adopting home-based arrangements will affect worker performance. Introducing remote work could affect performance in two ways: (i) by changing the performance of inframarginal workers, those who are willing to work in person but can now work from home, and (ii) by drawing a different type of worker into the firm once the job is advertised as a work-from-home job. We separately identify selection into and treatment effects of flexible work arrangements using randomly assigned surprise upgrades to participants' initial job offers. The main job performance outcomes we measure are accuracy and time required to complete tasks.

Working from home reduces worker performance, with the effect driven by treatment rather than selection. Office-based work causes workers to complete tasks 18% more quickly ( $p = .01$ ) and 3% more accurately ( $p = .08$ ) compared with workers who were willing to work from the office but were upgraded to work from home. We do not find significant differences on the selection margin, suggesting that work-from-home compliers—those whose job take-up is marginal to the ability to work from home—are not systematically different in their performance from those who are willing to work from both home and office. In this context of piece-rate wages, the performance cost in completion time is borne by the worker. Examining how work patterns differ between treatment arms, flow effects can explain the negative effect of working from home on productivity. Defining a work session as a period of uninterrupted work in which fewer than 10 minutes passes between consecutive tasks following [Adams-Prassl et al. \(2025\)](#), working from home reduces work-session length—measured by the number of tasks completed before a break—by 40% ( $p < .01$ ; 24% when measured in minutes). These fragmented work patterns are costly to performance because of flow effects: workers complete tasks more quickly, and more accurately, when they work for a longer stretch of time without pauses.

Our article contributes to four literatures. First, we contribute to an active literature on barriers to and enablers of women's labor force participation in low- and middle-income countries, such as perceived and actual gender norms ([Bernhardt et al. 2018](#);

Bursztyn, González, and Yanagizawa-Drott 2020; Field et al. 2021; Agte and Bernhardt 2024; see Jayachandran 2021 for a review), psychological constraints (Orkin et al. 2023; McKelway 2025), intrahousehold bargaining power (Heath and Tan 2020; Abou Daher et al. 2023), safety and mobility (Cheema et al. 2026; Martinez et al. 2020; Field and Vyborny 2022; Siddique 2022), early childbearing (Miller 2010; Herrera, Sahn, and Villa 2019), and employer and client discrimination (Islam et al. 2021; Buchmann, Meyer, and Sullivan 2023). In addition, a small but growing set of papers explore how digital technology interacts with these barriers (Alhorr 2024; Jalota and Ho 2024). The review paper by Fletcher, Pande, and Troyer Moore (2017) proposes that one driver of low female employment in India is a mismatch between available jobs and women's preferences; our study shows one important dimension of mismatch is the desire for flexible work arrangements, particularly the ability to work from home or multitask work with childcare.

Second, while a body of work demonstrates that female workers value flexible work arrangements more highly than men do in high-income countries, these studies largely focus on workers in the labor force and examine how compensating differentials contribute to gender wage gaps (see Filer 1985; Goldin 2014; Goldin and Katz 2016; Mas and Pallais 2017; Wiswall and Zafar 2018). In countries like India, however, the first-order issue is not wage gaps but low labor market entry—by age 30, only 24% of Indian women and 15% of women in West Bengal, our study setting—have ever engaged in paid work, accounting for most who will ever begin (National Statistical Office 2022). A natural question, then, is to what extent women's preferences for flexibility explain low labor market entry in this context. We show that among out-of-labor-force women, job flexibility is often the deciding factor for starting paid work. We also show that women's preferences for flexibility are shaped by work experience, as the resulting shift in gender attitudes increases willingness to later accept less flexible jobs.

Third, we contribute to the literature on how economic behavior shapes gender norms. Prior observational work shows that economic conditions, such as plough versus hoe agriculture, shape gendered divisions of labor with long-run effects on norms (Boserup 1970; Alesina, Giuliano, and Nunn 2013; Carranza 2014; Hansen, Jensen, and Skovsgaard 2015; Becker 2025). Experimental evidence on how women's paid work shifts gender attitudes remains limited, aside from Field et al. (2021), which also

finds that norms change when women start work. Our experimental test finds that women's entry into paid work appears to kickstart a reinforcing cycle between employment and less traditional gender norms, complementing models in which beliefs about women's work evolve through learning (Fernández, Fogli, and Olivetti 2004; Fernández 2013).

Finally, we contribute to a growing literature about the effects of flexible work arrangements on job performance (Bloom et al. 2015; Choudhury, Foroughi, and Larson 2021; Bloom, Han, and Liang 2022; Choudhury et al. 2022; Aksoy et al. 2023) and to a literature about the effects of work-from-home on female labor force participation (Edwards and Field-Hendrey 2002; Mas and Pallais 2017; Bloom, Han, and Liang 2024; Tito 2024). Consistent with most prior work examining the effects of fully remote work, we find negative effects on performance (Gibbs, Mengel, and Siemroth 2023; Atkin, Schoar, and Shinde 2023; Adams-Prassl et al. 2025; Emanuel and Harrington 2024). While performance declines are often attributed to communication frictions (Brucks and Levav 2022), we find negative effects even in fully individual tasks.

The rest of the article is organized as follows. Section II describes the study population and design. Section III describes the empirical strategy for our three main analyses. Section IV examines effects of flexible work on labor force entry. Section V studies short-term work experience and mechanisms. Section VI analyzes effects on worker performance. Section VII concludes.

## II. EXPERIMENTAL DESIGN

### II.A. *Setting and Participant Characteristics*

We conduct our study in eight areas in and around Kolkata, West Bengal, India. The study includes three rural locations (Canning, Noorpur, and Basanti), three peri-urban areas (Atabagan, Baruipur, and Sodepur), and two urban neighborhoods (Tiljala and New Alipore). Participant recruitment was facilitated by our local partner NGO, the Calcutta Foundation, which has operated in the region since 1994 with programs focusing on education, disaster relief, gender issues, and health. Online Appendix Figure A.1 maps the study areas.

*1. Sample Selection.* Recruitment occurred through door-to-door canvassing and introductions facilitated by local contacts in

neighborhoods where the Calcutta Foundation (CF) had previously operated. We recruited geographically rather than from CF beneficiary lists, and women currently enrolled in CF skills training were ineligible for the study. CF's prior activities in these areas largely focused on health services and disaster relief rather than employment.

For inclusion in the study, households needed to have a female member who (i) could read and speak Bangla or Hindi,<sup>3</sup> (ii) had access to an Android smartphone, and (iii) was not currently in the labor force or currently enrolled in skills training. Women who had previously been enrolled in skills training remained eligible. These criteria were designed to identify women who were full-time homemakers and would likely remain so without the intervention, but who would have the skills and resources to do the job if randomly assigned to a job offer. We provide more information on sample recruitment and participation rates in [Online Appendix A.5](#).

Our recruitment approach does not guarantee a representative sample, but our participant demographics largely align with regional population characteristics on key dimensions. As shown in [Online Appendix Table A.6](#), our sample is similar to the average West Bengal household in household size, religion, and the presence of parents-in-law and children within the household. The large-scale survey data are from the National Family Health Survey (2019–2021) ([International Institute for Population Sciences and ICF 2022](#)) and the Periodic Labor Force Survey (2021–2022) ([National Statistical Office 2022](#)). The large-scale survey sample is restricted to West Bengal and women ages 18 to 60. Although the difference in means on some of these characteristics is significant, the magnitude of the differences is small across household size, presence of parents-in-law and children, and religion.

Given the demographic characteristics of an average adult woman in West Bengal, the study inclusion criteria are not highly restrictive. According to large-scale demographic surveys (the NFHS 2019–2021 and PLFS 2021–2022), 60% of women 18 to 60 years old in West Bengal have completed secondary school, 51.2%

3. Bangla (also known as Bengali) is the official language of West Bengal. Bangla is also widely spoken in Bangladesh and in other Indian states such as Tripura, Assam, and Jharkhand. Hindi is the most widely spoken language in India and is spoken by many people in West Bengal, especially in Kolkata and bordering districts.

own a mobile phone, and 17.9% are currently working for pay. Regarding technology access, all participants have access to Android smartphones (per our eligibility criteria), with 73% reporting owning their phone outright. This exceeds the smartphone penetration rate in the general population. Unfortunately, surveys that are representative of both urban and rural households in West Bengal do not include information about smartphone ownership specifically rather than cellphone ownership, but as a lower bound, the Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) for 2021 found that 58% of rural households in West Bengal have a smartphone, with likely higher rates in urban areas.

2. *Participant Demographics.* The women in our study are predominantly homemakers with limited prior labor market experience. The average participant is 30 years old and married. Half have completed education through 10th standard (age 15–16), and 14% have at least some undergraduate education. Three-quarters of participants are Hindu, with the remainder being Muslim. Fifty-two percent belong to a scheduled caste or other backward caste, which is somewhat lower than the regional average, with a corresponding higher representation from the open/general caste category. Household composition reflects typical family structures in the area according to representative surveys: the average household size is 4.6 members, and 40% of participants live with at least one parent-in-law. Many women have substantial child-care responsibilities, with three-quarters of participants having children under 18 and 48% having children under 8.

3. *Socioeconomic Status and Agency over Labor Supply.* Participating households report an average monthly income of 11,788 INR (approximately US\$142), placing them in the lower-middle-income bracket and somewhat below the West Bengal average. Most participants (69%) have never previously worked for pay. Notably, only 36% of participants report having the final decision-making authority over their own labor supply. The vast majority (86%) of remaining participants report that the final decision-making authority about their job take-up rests with their husbands. The other 14% say that different family members—father, mother, father-in-law, son, mother-in-law in order of response

frequency—would have the final say.<sup>4</sup> Study participants are more likely to report having the final say in their decision to work than women who were contacted but did not complete the baseline survey: 20.1% of contacted nonparticipants report having the final say in the decision to work, compared with 36.2% of those who agreed to participate in the study ( $p < .001$ ). It is not obvious whether the treatment effects of the study would have been larger or smaller for nonparticipants. On the one hand, they likely would have had lower job take-up rates, but on the other hand, we find that job flexibility makes the biggest difference in labor supply for more constrained women and that work experience in turn affects their attitudes most. We report a full comparison between women who were contacted and eventual study participants in [Online Appendix Table A.30](#).

*4. Gender Attitudes About Women and Work.* At the start of the study, many participating women hold traditional attitudes about the appropriate role for men and women in a household. For example, during the baseline survey, 67% of women agree that a woman's most important role is to be a good homemaker, and 64% agree that earning a living is the father's responsibility while childcare is the mother's responsibility. Approximately half (52%) of women also agree that a man should have the final say about decisions in his home, which is particularly relevant to women's labor supply because on average men express lower levels of support for women working—especially outside the home—than women themselves do ([Bernhardt et al. 2018](#); [Bursztyn et al. 2023](#)).

We aggregate women's levels of agreement with these statements, as well as 10 other gender-related attitudes on the baseline survey, to classify women as belonging to households that are “more traditional” or “less traditional” depending on how their views compare with those of the median study participant. We show results aggregating statements into a standardized index following [Kling, Liebman, and Katz \(2007\)](#).<sup>5</sup> For more information on the gender-attitudes index, including a list of all questions used as inputs into the index, see [Online Appendix A.3](#). If women themselves, their husbands, and their in-laws hold these views, it

4. [Online Appendix Figure A.2](#) reports respondents' baseline responses of who would have the final say in their labor supply decisions.

5. Results using [Anderson \(2008\)](#) aggregation as a robustness check show similar conclusions ([Online Appendix Tables A.14, A.17, and A.19](#)).

may be difficult for women to take jobs that require spending an extended period of time outside the home, away from their home-making responsibilities. These attitudes help to motivate the jobs offered in the experiment, which are particularly amenable to flexible, at-home work arrangements.

## II.B. Job Description

1. *Jobs Platform.* We partner with a local-language smartphone-based tasks platform in India to offer the intervention jobs. The interface for the job app is presented in [Online Appendix Figure A.6](#). The jobs involve piece-rate paid tasks to contribute to Hindi or Bangla speech data sets, which require participants to speak into their phones and record their voices. The platform's clients build these speech data sets in low-resourced languages to train speech recognition algorithms because a large and growing population of digital technology users in India speak one of the country's many languages that do not yet have the labeled speech data sets necessary to develop voice-based applications ([Abraham et al. 2020](#); [Kumar et al. 2022](#)).

Although the jobs platform hosts data annotation tasks across a wide variety of domains, we concentrate on speech data sets because of several advantages for our study. One advantage is that we can verify from submitted voice tasks if a woman rather than a man seems to be completing the tasks, even if the participant works remotely. Second, we can listen for children's voices in the background of the speech recordings, which allows us to implement our work arrangement variations that do not allow for multi-tasking work with childcare. Third, there is a good justification for why it is valuable specifically for women to do these tasks, which is that existing data sets underrepresent women's voices, which are important for training voice-based algorithms that work well in interpreting female voice content (as discussed in [Tatman 2017](#); [Garnerin, Rossato, and Besacier 2019](#); [Fucci et al. 2023](#)).

Jobs fitting this description have grown rapidly since the COVID-19 pandemic ([Goldin 2021](#)). Remote work in the United States increased fivefold after 2019, and online gig opportunities are expanding in developing economies ([Barrero, Bloom, and Davis 2023](#); [Datta et al. 2023](#)). These gains in flexibility appear durable ([Aksoy et al. 2022](#)) and may have contributed to higher female labor force participation in high-income contexts ([Bauer and Wang 2023](#); [Tito 2024](#)), with potentially larger effects in

developing countries where mobility and childcare constraints are greater.

2. *Task Structure.* There are four types of paid tasks, which participants can choose to do in either Hindi or Bangla. The simplest tasks involve reading aloud a sentence that appears on the screen. These sentences are selected from a database of common phone or computer commands (e.g. “set an alarm for 7 am tomorrow morning”) that previous clients requested and paid for. The rest of the tasks require a higher cognitive load, and we classify them as “difficult” tasks for the purposes of analysis, although we also present results for all task types individually. The first difficult task involves reading a sentence backward, which we introduce to require more concentration. The second difficult task involves finding a specific sentence within a paragraph and reading that sentence out loud. These tasks require more intensive concentration because workers must read longer passages carefully. Last, there are open-ended questions for participants to answer, which our job platform partners were interested in collecting.

Participants receive 4,000 tasks to complete over the course of one month, with 1,000 new tasks refreshed each week that expire after seven days. Each week, workers are presented with 700 of the simplest tasks, 140 of the find-words-in-paragraph tasks, 150 read-sentence-backward tasks, and 10 open-ended tasks. If participants are unsatisfied with their first attempt, they can reattempt each task an unlimited number of times. The tasks are presented in a fixed order, but participants can skip any and as many tasks as they want.

3. *Payment.* Participants earn up to one rupee per task they complete, with payments processed weekly according to task quality. Payments were deposited directly into women’s bank accounts, except in a small number of cases in which women said they could not be paid into bank accounts, in which case they were paid in cash. Each completed task is assessed by a separate team of validators hired by our partners, who indicate whether they hear children’s voices in the background of the task recordings and score each task on accuracy using a 0–2 scale. This scoring rule implies participants could earn up to 4,000 INR (approximately US\$48) over the course of the intervention jobs, which is equivalent to 34% of the average household monthly income in the study. The task payment rate is set by the jobs platform and is the same as

TABLE I  
DESCRIPTION OF WORK ARRANGEMENTS

| Work arrangement                | Time flexibility | Multitasking with childcare | Work from home |
|---------------------------------|------------------|-----------------------------|----------------|
| Home: Fully Flexible            | Yes              | Yes                         | Yes            |
| Home: Time Inflexible           | No               | Yes                         | Yes            |
| Home: Child Inflexible          | Yes              | No                          | Yes            |
| Home: Time and Child Inflexible | No               | No                          | Yes            |
| Office                          | (Yes)            | No                          | No             |

*Notes.* This table presents the five work arrangements included in the experiment. The work arrangements varied in three characteristics: flexibility in time, multitasking work with childcare, and work-from-home. In work arrangements with time flexibility, workers could work at any hours they wished throughout the job, whereas in time-inflexible arrangements they had to commit to a particular time slot and then could only work during that shift for the rest of the job. In work arrangements that included the ability to multitask work with childcare, workers were told that it would be completely all right for them to have children next to them while they work; in jobs without this feature, workers were told that they could not have children next to them while working. In the office work arrangement, workers had to come to a nearby office to complete their tasks. There were eight offices set up (one in each area or neighborhood of recruitment). The offices were open from 10 am to 6 pm five days a week.

the payment rate offered to other workers on the platform for the same work. Per hour, this payment rate is also roughly equal to the wages advertised for data annotators in India on websites including Indeed.com.

4. *Implementing the Work Arrangements.* The five work arrangements vary across three dimensions: time, multitasking with childcare, and location (see Table I). The most flexible job offered, *Home: Fully Flexible*, allows workers to work from home, at any time they choose, and while multitasking their work with childcare. In each subsequent job, one or more dimensions are switched off.

i. *Time Flexibility.* In the time-flexible groups (*Home: Fully Flexible* and *Home: Child Inflexible*), workers can work for as many hours as they like and at any time of day to complete the tasks before they expire. The *Office* group is time-flexible, but with the constraint that women can choose their work hours within the 10 am–6 pm window when the office is open. In the time-inflexible groups (*Home: Time Inflexible* and *Home: Time and Child Inflexible*), participants choose a three-hour time slot during the job offer stage, and they can only work during that time slot for the rest of the month. Most workers could easily complete the tasks they were assigned in a given week if they worked for all hours during their time slot. Even the participants in the fifth percentile for

speed could complete, or at least attempt, the thousand tasks per week in approximately 12 hours. To enforce these work shifts, engineers working for the jobs platform altered the smartphone application so that it was possible to set time constraints. In the time-inflexible work arrangements, the smartphone application would not open for participants outside of their allotted work hours.

*ii. Multitasking Work with Childcare.* In the work arrangement groups that include the ability to multitask work with childcare (*Home: Fully Flexible* and *Home: Time Inflexible*), workers are told that they can have their children next to them while they work. In the groups that do not include the ability to multitask with childcare (*Home: Child Inflexible* and *Home: Time and Child Inflexible*), participants are told that it is not acceptable to have their children next to them while they work. If children's voices were heard in the background of their submitted tasks (determined by a separate team of validators), workers were not paid for those tasks.

*iii. Working from the Office.* In four out of five work arrangements, participants work from home, while in the Office group they are required to work from one of our offices. We set up an office in each of the eight recruitment areas such that workers could reach them by walking or by travelling a short distance by vehicle (a two-wheeler or three-wheeler). If workers want to travel by vehicle, we reimburse them for any associated financial commute costs. Participants are not allowed to bring their children to the office. The office was open between 10 am and 6 pm five days a week while the study was running (Monday–Friday in most areas and Sunday–Thursday in the Muslim-majority area). Last, the participant's coworkers and managers are all women, shutting down concerns about harassment or other potential negative consequences of a workplace with men.

## *II.C. Timeline and Randomization*

Study implementation was staggered across eight areas, beginning in April 2022 and ending in January 2023. See [Figure I](#) for a flowchart describing the experimental design.

*1. Recruitment, Informed Consent, and Baseline Surveys.* During study recruitment, potential participants are not told that

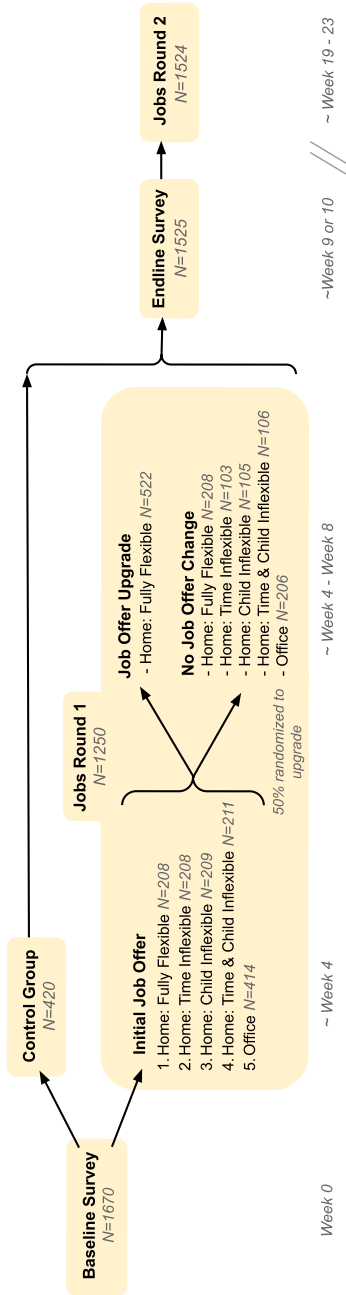


FIGURE I  
Experimental Design

This figure illustrates the five stages of the experimental design. Eligible households complete a baseline survey and are randomized into receiving a job offer or to the control group. The jobs vary along three dimensions: flexibility in choosing work hours, the ability to multitask work with childcare, and the ability to work from home. Time flexibility and childcare flexibility are cross-randomized, yielding five job groups. After accepting or declining, half of participants who initially received an inflexible job are randomly selected for an upgrade to the most flexible job. Participants then complete their month-long part-time job. Within two weeks of job completion, participants complete an endline survey. Two to three months later, they are offered another randomly assigned short-term job (Jobs Round 2) that varies along the same dimensions as the initial jobs.

the study could include a job opportunity to avoid selection into the experiment based on interest in work. If women are eligible and consent to participate, they complete a baseline survey that covers demographics, gender attitudes, agency, technology use, psychological well-being, and social contacts.

2. *Jobs Round 1 (R1): Initial Offers.* After the baseline survey, we randomly assign households to the control group, which receives no job offer, or to one of the five job groups in [Table I](#) for their initial job offer. Randomization is stratified by three characteristics: area, individual smartphone ownership, and whether the participant has a child under age eight.<sup>6</sup> Participants can accept or reject the job offer or else ask us to call back in a day or two if they need more time, for example, to discuss the job offer with family members.

3. *R1: Surprise Upgrades.* After participants decide to accept or reject their initial job offers, we randomly select half of the participants who were assigned to any job other than *Home: Fully Flexible* to be surprised with an upgrade to the most flexible job. Women who were randomly assigned to an upgrade but turned down the initial less flexible job are also offered the most flexible job. We include these randomly assigned surprise upgrades, following [Karlan and Zinman \(2009\)](#), to separately identify the characteristics of women who select into flexible work arrangements from the effects of those arrangements. To estimate selection, we compare measures of job performance between participants who initially accepted the most flexible job with participants who were upgraded to the most flexible job after initially accepting a less flexible job. This strategy to measure selection holds constant the actual work arrangement while varying worker type (i.e., flexibility compliers, women who will only work when the job is flexible, compared to inframarginal workers). To estimate treatment effects of flexibility, we compare job performance between participants who initially accepted an inflexible job and were upgraded versus those who also accepted an inflexible job but did not get a surprise upgrade. This strategy holds constant worker type while randomly varying the work arrangement. In the results section, we focus on the comparison between *Office* and *Home*:

6. One region, New Alipore, was not stratified further for randomization because of the small number of participating households (66).

*Fully Flexible* to estimate the effects of working from home on job performance. After the upgrades, the jobs are implemented for one month as described in [Section II.B](#). We refer to these as R1 jobs in the rest of the article.

4. *Endline Surveys.* After the randomized jobs intervention, participants complete an endline survey. This survey takes place within two weeks of job completion for treated participants, and the timing of surveys for control participants is selected to balance the timing of those in the treatment group. The endline survey includes modules such as gender attitudes, agency, and psychological well-being.

5. *Jobs Round 2 (R2).* Two to three months after R1, each study participant is approached and offered another randomly selected job. We refer to these as R2 jobs in the rest of the article. The jobs in this second round vary across the same three dimensions of flexibility as in R1, and they again last for one month. In addition to the five digital gig work jobs offered in R1, R2 introduces two non-digital jobs that consist of sewing masks, making jewelry, or constructing bags. These non-digital jobs are paid according to piece rates that vary by output quality. For the non-digital jobs, there are two possible work arrangements: one work-from-home, and one from the office. We cannot enforce the ability to choose work hours or multitask work with childcare for tasks that are not completed on the jobs platform. The purpose of the non-digital jobs is to understand whether any treatment effects on interest in work are digital-specific or apply to interest in paid work more generally. Participants have an equal likelihood of being randomly assigned to any of the seven possible round two jobs (two *Home: Fully Flexible*, one *Home: Child Inflexible*, one *Home: Time Inflexible*, one *Home: Time and Child Inflexible*, and two *Office*).

## II.D. Randomization, Balance, and Attrition

[Online Appendix Table A.1](#) presents means and standard deviations of participant characteristics in the control and treatment groups after randomization into initial job offers, and [Online Appendix Table A.2](#) presents means and standard deviations of participant characteristics in the control and treatment groups after randomization into final job offers. Randomization produced groups that are balanced across most characteristics of interest, although households in the treatment group are more

likely to be Hindu, a difference that is significant at the 10% level. [Online Appendix Table A.4](#) presents the same for participants who completed the endline survey; 1,525 households completed the endline survey with balanced attrition. The endline survey completion rate is 91.1% for the treatment group and 91.9% for the control group. The groups remain similar on average across important covariates. As with immediately after randomization, the treatment group is more likely to be Hindu ( $p = .064$ ). At the endline survey stage, there is one more imbalance significant at the 10% level, which is that the control group is more likely to have parents-in-law in the household ( $p = .119$  after randomization, and  $p = .098$  at the time of the endline survey). We also compare attrition across different groups ([Online Appendix Table A.5](#)), in both overall rates and key baseline outcome variables, and do not find any significant imbalances in attrition between treatment arms. We also present a balance table for randomization into R1 versus R2 job offers in [Online Appendix Table A.3](#), which is the relevant grouping for our gateway-jobs analysis. Again, the same two variables (religion and living with in-laws) are significantly different between groups at the 10% level. To control for any imbalances, we present results from specifications that include the union of covariates selected by double post-LASSO that are predictive of treatment assignment and outcomes of interest in regressions estimating the effects of treatment ([Belloni, Chernozhukov, and Hansen 2014](#)).

### III. EMPIRICAL STRATEGY

This section presents the empirical strategy for our three main analyses. We first summarize the research questions and corresponding outcomes, then present the estimating equations, and finally describe our approach to identification, heterogeneity analysis, and inference. This strategy applies throughout [Sections IV–VI](#), which present results.

#### *III.A. Research Questions and Outcomes*

Our experimental design enables us to address three main research questions:

- i. **Labor force entry:** Does offering flexible work arrangements increase women's entry into paid work, and which dimensions of flexibility matter most?

TABLE II  
RESEARCH QUESTIONS, PRIMARY OUTCOMES, EXPERIMENTAL VARIATIONS,  
AND EQUATIONS

| Research question           | Primary outcomes                     | Experimental variation                     | Equation |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|----------|
| (1) Labor force entry       | R1 job take-up                       | Random assignment to R1 work arrangements  | (1)      |
| (2) Gateway jobs            | R2 job take-up                       | R1 × R2 assignment                         | (2)      |
| (3) Work experience effects | Gender attitudes, agency, well-being | Any job offer vs. control                  | (3)      |
| (4a) WFH treatment effects  | Accuracy, completion time            | Surprise upgrades (among office accepters) | (4)      |
| (4b) WFH selection effects  | Accuracy, completion time            | Initial offer accepted (among upgraders)   | (5)      |

Notes. R1 = Round 1; R2: Round 2; WFH = work from home.

- ii. **Gateway jobs:** Can initial experience with flexible work serve as a stepping stone to less flexible jobs in the future?
- iii. **Worker performance:** How does working from home affect job performance, through both treatment effects on inframarginal workers and selection of different worker types?

Table II summarizes the primary outcomes, experimental variation, and estimating equations corresponding to each research question.

In addition to these primary outcomes, we examine several secondary outcomes to shed light on mechanisms and broader effects: gender attitudes of women, women’s agency and psychological well-being. We describe these outcomes as they arise in the relevant results sections.

III.B. Estimating Equations

1. *Effects of Flexibility on Job Take-Up.* To estimate how job flexibility affects women’s labor force entry, we compare take-up rates across randomly assigned work arrangements. The sample consists of all 1,670 women enrolled in the study and assigned to either the control group or to receive a job offer during R1. We

estimate:

$$\text{StartsWork}_i = \sum_{j=1}^5 \beta_j \mathbb{1}\{\text{FinalWorkArrangement}_i = j\} + \mu_s + \varepsilon_i, \quad (1)$$

where  $\text{StartsWork}_i$  is an indicator equal to one if participant  $i$  starts the R1 job she is randomly assigned to. The regressors  $\mathbb{1}\{\text{FinalWorkArrangement}_i = j\}$  are indicators for participant  $i$ 's final work arrangement, where  $j \in \{\text{Home: Fully Flexible}, \text{Home: Time Inflexible}, \text{Home: Child Inflexible}, \text{Home: Time and Child Inflexible}, \text{Office}\}$ . The omitted category is the control group, for which  $\text{StartsWork}_i = 0$  for all participants. We include strata fixed effects  $\mu_s$  throughout. Because we are interested in the question of how many more women would enter the labor force under these different work arrangements, we do not include any control variables in this part of the analysis.

**2. Gateway-Job Effects on Future Labor Supply.** To test whether flexible work can serve as a stepping stone to less flexible jobs, we examine how R1 job assignment affects take-up of R2 jobs. Because willingness to take up a job increases approximately monotonically within subject along the spectrum of work arrangements on offer, we say that anyone whose R1 job assignment was more flexible than their R2 assignment was given a gateway-job sequence. Monotonicity refers to take-up decisions, not to the job features themselves: as Table I shows, the specific flexibility dimensions bundled into each arrangement do not nest perfectly (for example, the office job includes time flexibility to ensure non-negligible take-up). Instead, by monotonicity we mean that when women are asked if they would be willing to accept each of the five work arrangements, within each respondent there is a single crossing from responding yes to no for job take-up across the five work arrangements: *Office*, *Home: Time and Child Inflexible*, *Home: Child Inflexible*, *Home: Time Inflexible*, and *Home: Fully Flexible* (see Online Appendix Table A.10).

If monotonicity holds, then there are some women—gateway-job compliers—who would take up a more flexible R1 job but could not have taken up the less flexible R2 job if it had been offered during R1. That is, their labor supply is marginal to the difference in flexibility between their R1 and R2 assignments. If work experience expands the set of jobs women can accept, these gateway-

job compliers may no longer be marginal to flexibility by the time they receive their R2 offer and would therefore be more likely to start work than their counterparts in the control group who did not have the opportunity to gain work experience.

We estimate:

$$(2) \quad y_i = \beta_1 \mathbb{1}[\text{R1} > \text{R2}]_i + \beta_2 \mathbb{1}[\text{R1} \leq \text{R2}]_i + \gamma_{r(i)} + \mathbf{X}'_i \delta + \mu_s + \varepsilon_i,$$

where  $\mathbb{1}[\text{R1} > \text{R2}]_i$  indicates assignment to a gateway-job sequence in which the R1 job was more flexible than the R2 job, and  $\mathbb{1}[\text{R1} \leq \text{R2}]_i$  indicates assignment to a non-gateway sequence. We include R2 work-arrangement fixed effects  $\gamma_{r(i)}$ , LASSO-selected controls  $\mathbf{X}_i$ , and strata fixed effects  $\mu_s$ . The omitted category is the control group, who received no job offer in R1. Thus,  $\beta_1$  captures the effect of being assigned to a gateway-job sequence—relative to receiving no R1 offer—on R2 job take-up, conditional on R2 job assignment.

### 3. *Effects of a Job Offer on Attitudes, Agency, and Well-Being.*

To estimate the effects of a job offer on outcomes that may serve as mechanisms such as gender attitudes, agency, and psychological well-being, we compare women randomly assigned to receive any job offer with women in the control group. We estimate:

$$(3) \quad y_i = \beta \mathbb{1}\{\text{JobOffer}_i = 1\} + \mathbf{X}'_i \delta + \mu_s + \varepsilon_i,$$

where  $y_i$  is the outcome of interest measured at endline,  $\mathbb{1}\{\text{JobOffer}_i = 1\}$  is an indicator for being assigned to any job offer during R1 pooling across all work arrangements,  $\mathbf{X}_i$  are LASSO-selected controls, and  $\mu_s$  are strata fixed effects. The coefficient  $\beta$  captures the intent-to-treat effect of being offered a job on the outcome, relative to the control group. These outcomes are of interest both in their own right and as potential mechanisms: for example, if work experience shifts gender attitudes, this could help explain the gateway-job effect documented using [equation \(2\)](#). For outcomes where we expect heterogeneous effects by baseline levels, we also estimate this equation separately for subgroups (e.g., women with more versus less traditional baseline gender attitudes).

4. *Treatment Effects of Work-from-Home on Performance.* To estimate how working from home affects job performance for inframarginal workers—those willing to work from the office—we leverage randomly assigned surprise upgrades. Among workers

who initially accepted the office job, we compare the performance of those who remained in the office arrangement with those randomly selected for an upgrade to the most flexible arrangement. We estimate the following individual-by-task level regression:

$$(4) \quad y_{it} = \beta^T \mathbb{1}\{\text{FinalJob}_i = \text{Office}\} + \mathbf{X}'_{it} \delta + \mu_s + \varepsilon_{it},$$

where  $y_{it}$  is participant  $i$ 's performance on task  $t$  (measured as accuracy on a 0–2 scale or completion time in seconds),  $\mathbb{1}\{\text{FinalJob}_i = \text{Office}\}$  is an indicator variable equal to one if  $i$  was not randomly selected to be upgraded to the flexible arrangement,  $\mathbf{X}_{it}$  are LASSO-selected controls, and  $\mu_s$  are strata fixed effects. The omitted category consists of workers who were randomly selected for an upgrade after accepting the *Office* job. The coefficient  $\beta^T$  represents the causal effect of work-from-office (versus work-from-home) on performance, holding worker type constant. Note this comparison is with a work-from-home arrangement that includes the ability to multitask work with childcare and to flexibly choose work hours.

5. *Selection Effects of Work-from-Home on Performance.* To characterize flexibility compliers—women who work only if offered flexible jobs—we compare performance of different worker types under identical work arrangements. Among all workers ultimately working under *Home: Fully Flexible*, we compare (i) those who initially accepted *Home: Fully Flexible* with (ii) those who accepted *Office* before being upgraded:

$$(5) \quad y_{it} = \beta^S \mathbb{1}\{\text{InitialOffer}_i = \text{Home: Fully Flexible}\} + \mathbf{X}'_{it} \delta + \mu_s + \varepsilon_{it},$$

where  $\mathbb{1}\{\text{InitialOffer}_i = \text{Home: Fully Flexible}\}$  is an indicator variable equal to one if participant  $i$  was initially offered the flexible arrangement. The omitted category is the same as for the treatment-effects analysis: workers who were initially offered and accepted the *Office* job but were randomly selected for an upgrade. We note that group (i) combines both flexibility compliers with those who would accept any job offer. To estimate the share of group (i) who are flexibility compliers, we scale the raw difference in productivity between groups (i) and (ii) using the shares of participants who start work across different work arrangements. Since 47.9% of participants started work when offered *Home: Fully Flexible* while 14.6% started work when offered *Office*, we assume that of the 47.9% who started *Home: Fully*

*Flexible*, 14.6% would have also taken up the office job if offered it, leaving  $1 - \frac{14.6}{47.9} = 0.695$  as the share of women who are flexibility compliers. That is, they would accept *Home: fully flexible* but not office-based work. Since we are interested in characterizing the differences between these worker types, we do not include LASSO-selected controls in this part of the analysis.

To summarize the comparison groups across analyses: throughout, we use the pure control group (no R1 job offer) as the omitted category for the labor force entry, gateway job, and treatment effects of work analyses (equation (1)–(3)). For the performance analyses (equation (4) and (5)), the control group cannot serve as the omitted category because these individuals do not complete tasks. We therefore use a consistent omitted category across both the treatment and selection analyses: workers who accepted the office job and were randomly selected for an upgrade to *Home: Fully Flexible*.

### III.C. Identification

Our identification strategy relies on three sources of experimental variation.

1. *Random Assignment to Work Arrangements.* Job offers in both rounds are randomly assigned, stratified by area, individual smartphone ownership, and whether the participant has a child under age eight. Random assignment ensures that comparisons across work arrangements identify causal effects of job flexibility on take-up. [Online Appendix Tables A.1](#) and [A.2](#) demonstrate balance across treatment arms during randomization of initial and final R1 job offers.

2. *Surprise Upgrades.* After participants decide whether to accept or reject their initial job offers, we randomly select half of those assigned to arrangements other than *Home: Fully Flexible* to receive an upgrade to the most flexible arrangement. This design, following [Karlan and Zinman \(2009\)](#), enables us to separately identify treatment and selection effects of flexibility on worker performance. Treatment effects are identified by comparing performance among workers who accepted an inflexible job, some of whom were randomly upgraded. Selection effects are identified by comparing workers under identical (flexible) arrangements who differ only in their revealed willingness to accept office work.

3. *Gateway-Job Sequences.* The combination of random assignment in R1 and R2 generates exogenous variation in whether participants receive a gateway-job sequence (R1 more flexible than R2). The control group, which received no R1 offer, provides the comparison for estimating whether initial work experience affects future labor supply. The key identifying assumption is that, conditional on R2 assignment, R1 assignment only affects R2 take-up through the experience of R1 work (or the offer itself for those who declined).

### III.D. Heterogeneity Analysis

We examine treatment-effect heterogeneity in two ways. First, for each outcome, we split the sample at the median of the baseline level of that outcome or a closely related characteristic (e.g., previous work experience for labor supply outcomes; baseline traditional attitudes for gender attitudes; baseline agency for agency outcomes). Second, to identify which baseline characteristics most strongly predict heterogeneous treatment effects, we use causal forests (Athey and Imbens 2016; Wager and Athey 2018) and report variable-importance scores.

### III.E. Estimation and Inference

1. *Control Variables.* All specifications include strata fixed effects. For equations (2), (3), and (4), we also present specifications with controls selected by double post-LASSO (Belloni, Chernozhukov, and Hansen 2014), which identifies variables predictive of both treatment assignment and outcomes of interest. Every selection draws from a single common pool of baseline candidates, which is the set of variables measured on the baseline survey along with baseline indices and survey-process variables, such as which enumerator administered the survey. One group of candidates is admitted to a subset of specifications only: the randomized ordering of the gender-attitudes module is part of the available control pool when a gender-attitudes outcome is on the left side but nowhere else. Controls are selected on the sample used for estimation, so a specification estimated on a subgroup selects its controls in that subgroup rather than inheriting those chosen on the full sample. Missing values among the possible controls are filled and flagged so that the estimation sample does not change with the candidate pool. For the job take-up analysis in equation (1), we do not include control variables in the main specification

because this would prevent us from getting the raw population difference in labor supply under different work arrangements. For the selection analysis in [equation \(5\)](#), we do not include LASSO-selected baseline control variables as we seek to characterize the overall differences between these worker types, including any differences in observable characteristics.

*2. Standard Errors.* We report Huber-White heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors throughout in [equation \(1\)](#), [\(2\)](#), and [\(3\)](#). For task-level regressions ([equation \(4\)](#) and [\(5\)](#)), we present results clustering at the individual level.

#### IV. EXTENSIVE-MARGIN LABOR SUPPLY RESPONSE TO JOB FLEXIBILITY

##### IV.A. *Effects of Flexibility on Job Take-Up*

Estimating [equation \(1\)](#), we find that job flexibility dramatically increases women's extensive-margin labor supply by more than three times, from 15% for *Office* to 48% ( $p < .001$ ) for *Home: Fully Flexible* (see [Figure II](#)). These estimates reflect the differences in the share of women who start work according to their final job offer after the randomly selected upgrades. To benchmark the magnitude of this effect, the bundled effect of job flexibility on take-up (+33 percentage points or 228%) is larger than the effects of previously studied levers that successfully increased women's labor supply. For example, correcting men's second-order beliefs about social-image costs of women working increased sign-up rates for a job-matching service by 9 percentage points or 36% ([Bursztyn, González, and Yanagizawa-Drott 2020](#)), a self-efficacy intervention increased job take-up rates by 5 percentage points or 32% ([McKelway 2025](#)), and giving women control over their earnings increased women's participation in paid work by 5 percentage points or 13% ([Field et al. 2021](#)).

The effect of job flexibility is also large relative to women's labor supply response to wages, which we estimate in a companion experiment in Mumbai. There, increasing women's monthly wage offers nearly five times from 5,000 INR (US\$60) to 24,000 INR (US\$289) raised job take-up by only 7 percentage points (32%), a marginal response of roughly 0.37 percentage points per additional 1,000 INR per month ([Jalota and Ho 2024](#)). Extrapolating that marginal response linearly, the 33 percentage points effect of

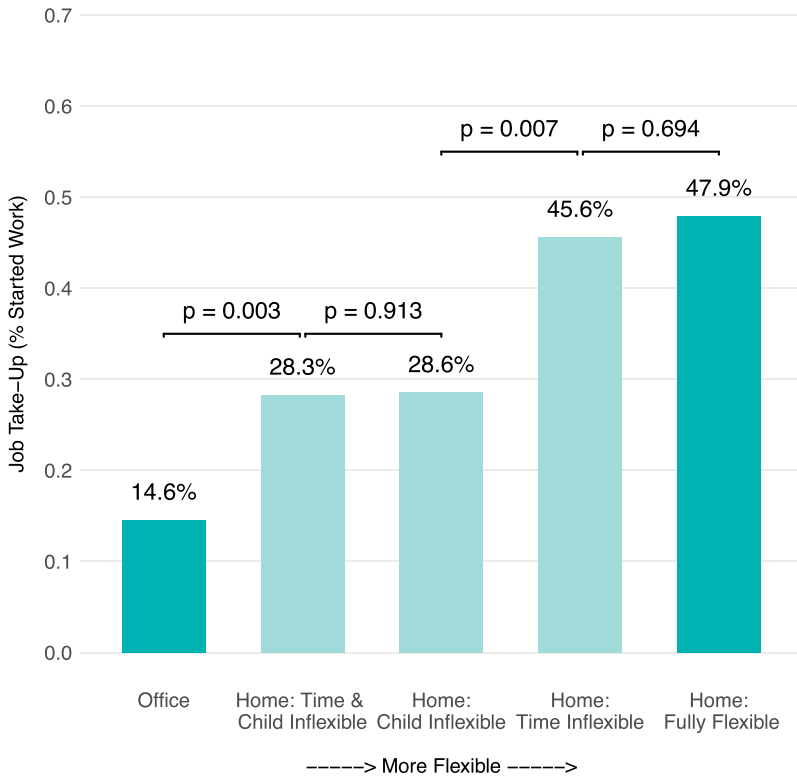


FIGURE II

## The Effect of Flexible Work Arrangements on Take-Up of Jobs

This figure plots the take-up rate for each of the five jobs during jobs round 1. The sample consists of the 1,250 women in treatment households. The plotted take-up rates correspond to participants' final job offers; that is, women assigned to different initial job offers but who have the same final job offer after randomly assigned upgrades are implemented are pooled together. Take-up is measured as a binary variable equal to one if the participant starts work (i.e., submits any completed tasks to the employer). This figure plots the raw take-up rates for each of the jobs, while the standard errors for these regressions, along with pairwise tests of equality between job take-up rates, are presented in [Online Appendix Table A.7](#), column (1). In these regressions, the comparison group is the control group, and we control for strata fixed effects and estimate Huber-White heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. The brackets above the bars show  $p$ -values for pairwise tests of equality between job take-up rates of different work arrangements.

bundled flexibility in West Bengal corresponds to a wage increase of approximately 89,600 INR (US\$1,080) per month—far above the average monthly income of these households.<sup>7</sup>

The effect of job flexibility on women's job take-up varies but remains large across a range of study subsamples. [Online Appendix Figure A.3](#) plots job take-up for each work arrangement across sample splits by religion, caste, education, cohabitation with in-laws, having a young child, having one's own smartphone, previous work experience, agency over one's labor supply, and gender attitudes. Using the causal-forest approach described in [Section III](#), we find that gender attitudes emerge as the characteristic most important to mediating the effect of job flexibility on take-up (see [Online Appendix Table A.16](#)). The variable pool included all baseline variables, including the nine used to split the sample in [Online Appendix Figure A.3](#).

Job flexibility makes a difference to job take-up decisions of all subsets of women, especially for women from more traditional households. The job take-up difference by gender attitudes in levels as well as the elasticity of labor supply appears even among women without young children. [Online Appendix Figure A.4](#) splits the sample by gender attitudes as well as having a child under age eight.<sup>8</sup> Regardless of whether a woman has a child younger than eight, more traditional women are less likely to start work and more likely to change their labor supply in response to job flexibility.

Finally, the large effect of job flexibility on women's job take-up is robust to changing the cutoff of number of tasks completed that qualifies as having started work (see [Online Appendix Table A.7](#) columns (2)–(4) for results using 10 tasks, 50 tasks, and 100 tasks as cutoffs). [Online Appendix Table A.8](#) reports results from the same regressions, but with the inclusion of LASSO-selected control variables. LASSO-selected controls change the

7. This calculation is a linear extrapolation of a level-on-level take-up response, not an elasticity, and it extends beyond the wage range studied in Mumbai; we report it as an order-of-magnitude benchmark only. The linear extrapolation is the conservative choice. The Mumbai estimates imply an elasticity of job take-up with respect to wages of roughly 0.08, at which reproducing the 228% proportional increase in take-up generated by flexibility would require a wage several orders of magnitude above 24,000 INR.

8. Having a child under age eight was one of our stratification criteria for randomization, chosen to reflect an age at which it may be possible to let a child self-supervise for a couple of hours while doing paid work.

take-up rate effects very little, by at most 1 percentage point. The effect is also not driven by job upgrades, as shown in [Online Appendix Table A.9](#), which presents the coefficients for all initial-offer job groups separately. Differences in job take-up between women initially assigned to *Home: Fully Flexible* and women who were initially assigned to another arrangement but were randomly selected for an upgrade to *Home: Fully Flexible* are small and insignificant across all dimensions of flexibility.

#### IV.B. Mechanisms: Dimensions of Flexibility

To understand the mechanisms driving the effect of this bundled job flexibility on women's labor supply, we sequentially shut down time flexibility, multitasking-with-childcare flexibility, and the ability to work from home in job offers that are randomly assigned across participants. Understanding which features of flexible work arrangements affect women's participation in paid work is important for designing jobs that can include more women into the labor market. Take-up rates in this subsection are the strata-adjusted estimates from [Online Appendix Table A.7](#), column (1) rather than the raw rates plotted in [Figure II](#). The two differ by less than a percentage point for every arrangement except *Home: Time and Child Inflexible*, where the raw rate is 28.3% and the strata-adjusted estimate is 29.3%; the office rate likewise appears as 15% in the previous subsection and 14% here.

- i. **Time flexibility.** The ability to choose hours flexibly does not make a significant difference to women's job take-up. Time flexibility has no significant effect regardless of whether women are assigned to a work arrangement in which they can multitask work with childcare. The job take-up rate for *Home: Time Inflexible* is 46% as compared with 48% for *Home: Fully Flexible* ( $p$ -value for the difference = .69). In this comparison, both work arrangements include the ability to work from home and multitask work with childcare and differ only in time flexibility. Then, to examine the effect of time flexibility when women are not able to multitask work with childcare, we compare the take-up rate for *Home: Child Inflexible* with the take-up rate for *Home: Time and Child Inflexible*. Both take-up rates are 29% ( $p$ -value for the difference = .91).

These results show that the out-of-labor-force women in our study can, and choose to, set aside consistent hours of their day to work for pay. The lack of effect of time flexibility holds regardless of whether the work allows them to multitask work with childcare, which suggests that lack of time, at least for part-time work, is not the binding constraint that prevents these women from entering the labor market.

- ii. **Multitasking-with-childcare flexibility.** The ability to multitask work with childcare is an important determinant of women's job take-up. The share of women who start work increases from 29% for *Home: Child Inflexible* to 48% for *Home: Fully Flexible* (+19 percentage points or 68%,  $p < .01$ ). Similarly, the share of women who start work increases from 29% for the *Home: Time and Child Inflexible* to 46% for *Home: Time Inflexible* (+17 percentage points or 57%,  $p = .01$ ). If children were quiet while workers recorded their tasks, it would not be possible to know if workers had children next to them while they worked. However, the lower job take-up for childcare-inflexible jobs suggests that women did take this constraint seriously. Only a small share of the tasks submitted for review by women in the childcare-inflexible arrangements were marked as having children's voices in the background. Workers were not paid for flagged tasks, which reinforced the constraint and gave women a financial incentive to comply.
- iii. **Ability to work from home.** The ability to work from home—even at fixed hours and without multitasking with childcare—is also a consequential determinant of women's job take-up, increasing the share of women who start work from 14% for *Office* to 29% for *Home: Time and Child Inflexible* (+15 percentage points or 103%,  $p < .01$ ).

In sum, the extensive-margin labor supply decisions of 33% of women in our study are marginal to bundled job flexibility. A decomposition of this effect using random variation in work arrangements finds that approximately half of the effect can be attributed to the ability to multitask work with childcare (17–19 percentage points), and approximately half can be attributed to the ability to work from home independent of childcare concerns (15 percentage points).

TABLE III  
GATEWAY JOBS: EFFECTS OF JOBS ROUND 1 ASSIGNMENT ON JOBS ROUND 2 TAKE-UP

|                                     | Started work during jobs round 2 |                 |                       |                  |                 |                 |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------------|------------------|-----------------|-----------------|
|                                     | All participants                 |                 | Study = 1st paid work |                  |                 |                 |
|                                     |                                  |                 | Yes                   |                  | No              |                 |
|                                     | (1)                              | (2)             | (3)                   | (4)              | (5)             | (6)             |
| R1 more flexible than R2            | 0.05<br>(0.03)                   | 0.04<br>(0.03)  | 0.09**<br>(0.04)      | 0.09**<br>(0.04) | -0.02<br>(0.06) | -0.02<br>(0.06) |
| R1 less or equally flexible than R2 | -0.04<br>(0.03)                  | -0.04<br>(0.03) | -0.01<br>(0.04)       | -0.01<br>(0.04)  | -0.09<br>(0.06) | -0.09<br>(0.06) |
| Observations                        | 1,524                            | 1,524           | 1,049                 | 1,049            | 475             | 475             |
| Control mean                        | 0.42                             | 0.42            | 0.37                  | 0.37             | 0.51            | 0.51            |
| R2 work-arrangement fixed effects   | Yes                              | Yes             | Yes                   | Yes              | Yes             | Yes             |
| Strata fixed effects                | Yes                              | Yes             | Yes                   | Yes              | Yes             | Yes             |
| Lasso selected controls             | No                               | Yes             | No                    | Yes              | No              | Yes             |

Notes. This table presents results on effects of the initial jobs RCT on starting work during the second round of jobs. The outcome variable in all columns is an indicator variable equal to one if the participant starts the job that she was randomly assigned to during round 2 and is otherwise equal to zero. The omitted group is the control group. Treatment-group participants are categorized by the relative flexibility of their randomly assigned round 1 (R1) versus round 2 (R2) job assignments. Columns (1) and (2) report the effects of R1 job assignment on R2 job take-up for all participants. Columns (3)–(6) report effects separately by whether a participant had previous paid work experience before the study. All columns include R2 work-arrangement and strata fixed effects. Odd-numbered columns report results without additional controls, while even-numbered columns report results including controls selected by double post LASSO. Huber-White standard errors in parentheses are robust to heteroskedasticity. \*  $p < .10$ ; \*\*  $p < .05$ ; \*\*\*  $p < .01$ .

V. GATEWAY JOBS: FLEXIBLE, HOME-BASED JOBS AS A STEPPING STONE

V.A. Results

Women randomly assigned to a gateway-job sequence are more likely to start work in R2 conditional on their R2 job offer (Table III). Estimating equation (2), we find that assignment to a gateway-job sequence increases R2 job take-up by 4 percentage points for the full sample, though this effect is not statistically significant. Consistent with the stepping stone effect operating through learning from the experience of earning income, the effect is driven by women without previous work experience, who are 9 percentage points more likely to begin work ( $p = .02$ ). In contrast, there is no significant effect for women who already have experience with paid work ( $-2$  percentage points,  $p = .69$ ). Assignment to a non-gateway sequence, as represented by  $\hat{\beta}_2$ , also has no significant effect.

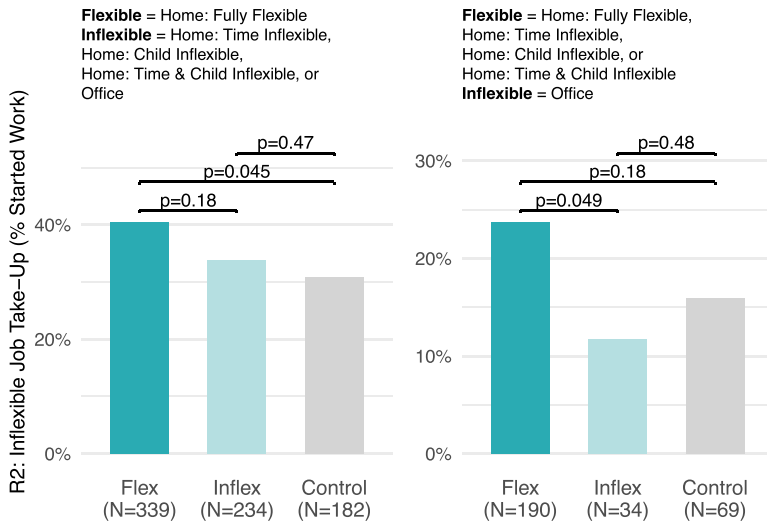
Figure III presents these gateway-jobs results graphically, showing that assignment to a flexible work arrangement in R1 increases take-up of inflexible work arrangements in R2 no matter where the line between “flexible” and “inflexible” is drawn. The dependent variable is the share of women who started their inflexible R2 job by whether their R1 job was flexible, inflexible, or absent (control). The two subfigures in each panel bracket the range of reasonable thresholds for defining flexibility: the left applies the narrowest definition, counting only *Home: Fully Flexible* as flexible, while the right applies the broadest, counting all home-based jobs as flexible and only office jobs as inflexible. Because each panel conditions on the woman having been offered an inflexible R2 job, and because a more restrictive definition of inflexible leaves fewer women in that category, the samples are larger on the left than on the right.

Among women without previous work experience (Panel A), those assigned to a flexible R1 job are more likely to take up an inflexible R2 job under each definition of flexibility. Under the narrowest threshold for defining flexibility (where only *Home: Fully Flexible* is considered flexible), 40.4% of women with a flexible R1 job started their R2 job, compared with 30.8% of control women ( $p = .045$ ). Under the broadest threshold (where all home-based arrangements are considered flexible), R2 take-up is 23.7% versus 15.9% for control ( $p = .18$ ). Take-up is just 11.8% for women whose R1 job was already inflexible, so that exposure to a flexible job during R1 raises take-up by 11.9 percentage points relative to exposure to an inflexible job during R1 ( $p = .049$ ). [Online Appendix Figure A.5](#) shows that the same pattern in R2 job take-up holds at the intermediate thresholds for defining flexibility.

In contrast, Panel B shows no gateway effect among women with previous work experience, consistent with the table. Their inflexible R2 job take-up does not differ systematically by R1 assignment under any threshold: under the narrowest definition of flexible, take-up is 37.8% for women with a flexible R1 job, 37.5% for those with an inflexible R1 job, and 44.1% for control (all pairwise  $p$ -values  $\geq 0.46$ ); the pattern remains flat and statistically insignificant under the broadest definition of flexible (26.5%, 23.5%, and 23.8%, respectively).

In the main specification, we use relative flexibility rather than any single threshold to (i) avoid choosing one arbitrary cut-off and (ii) improve statistical power by including all women whose R1 assignment was more flexible than their R2 assign-

## (A) First-Time Paid Workers: Inflexible R2 Take-Up



## (B) Had Previous Work Experience: Inflexible R2 Take-Up

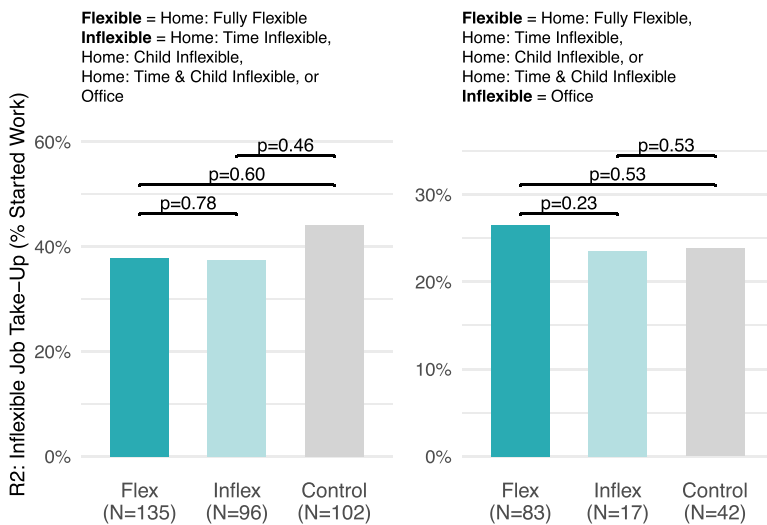


FIGURE III

Take-Up of Inflexible R2 Jobs by R1 Job Assignment

ment, rather than treating some gateway-job compliers as inframarginal. [Online Appendix Table A.11](#) reports the fully interacted specification, which estimates a separate effect for each  $R1 \times R2$  assignment pair. No individual cell is statistically distinguishable from zero, but the 10 cells corresponding to gateway sequences average +5.4 percentage points while the remaining 15 average -4.1 percentage points.

### V.B. Mechanisms

We consider possible mechanisms through which work experience might affect future labor supply. We first present evidence supporting gender attitudes as the primary mechanism and then assess the plausibility of alternative channels.

*1. Gender Attitudes as the Primary Mechanism.* Using the causal-forest approach described in [Section III](#), we identify which baseline covariates best predict heterogeneity in the gateway-job treatment effect. As reported in [Online Appendix Table A.18](#), the baseline gender-attitudes index emerges as the strongest predictor of treatment-effect heterogeneity, followed by baseline-survey duration and the agency index. That the gender-attitudes index ranks first among all candidate moderators, including all covariates collected at baseline, provides empirical support for our focus on gender attitudes as the key mechanism.

FIGURE III Continued

This figure shows take-up of inflexible round 2 (R2) jobs by the flexibility of a woman's round 1 (R1) job, testing for a "gateway" effect: whether exposure to more flexible work in R1 raises take-up of less flexible work in R2. The outcome variable is the share of women who started the R2 job they were randomly assigned. The five R1/R2 job types, ordered from most to least flexible, are *Home: Fully Flexible*, *Home: Time Inflexible*, *Home: Child Inflexible*, *Home: Time and Child Inflexible*, and *Office*. Each panel applies one threshold that divides these types into "Flexible" and "Inflexible," as listed in the panel heading, and restricts the sample to women whose R2 job was Inflexible under that threshold. The left side counts only *Home: Fully Flexible* jobs as Flexible (the narrowest definition), while the right side counts all home-based jobs as Flexible (the broadest). Because inclusion in this figure is conditional on the woman having an Inflexible R2 job, sample sizes are larger on the left than on the right. Bars report R2 take-up for women whose R1 job was Flexible, women whose R1 job was Inflexible, and women who received no R1 offer (control);  $N$  is the number of women in each group. Panel A restricts to women with no prior paid work, and Panel B to women with prior paid work experience. Brackets report regression-based  $p$ -values from specifications that control for strata fixed effects and covariates selected by double post LASSO.

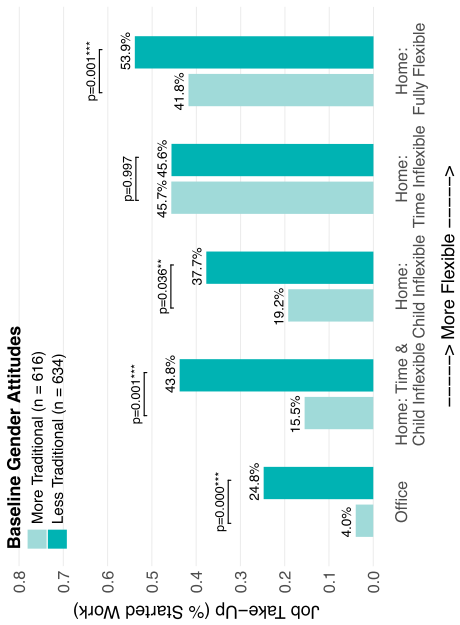
i. *Potential Pathways.* Traditional gender attitudes could constrain women's labor supply through two channels. First, traditional gender attitudes may lead women to view certain types of work as incompatible with their roles as wives and mothers, causing them to turn down jobs that conflict with this self-identity (Akerlof and Kranton 2000; Oh 2023). Second, traditional attitudes about household decision-making place greater weight on husbands' preferences than on women's own preferences, and husbands tend to express lower support for women's labor market engagement than women themselves do (Bernhardt et al. 2018; Bursztyn et al. 2023).

ii. *Empirical Evidence on Gender Attitudes as the Main Mechanism.* We present evidence for two relationships linking gender attitudes to labor supply. First, traditional gender attitudes constrain women's labor supply, particularly in less flexible jobs. Figure IV, Panel A shows R1 take-up rates for the five different work arrangements, split by whether women's baseline gender attitudes are more or less traditional than the median participant.<sup>9</sup> Across all work arrangements, traditional women have lower or approximately the same job take-up rates. Importantly, job flexibility is differentially more important for women with traditional gender views: labor supply elasticity with respect to flexibility increases in how traditional attitudes are.

Second, work experience shifts gender attitudes to become less traditional. Figure IV, Panel B shows that women randomly assigned to receive a job offer become 0.06 standard deviations less traditional ( $p = .02$ ). This effect is concentrated among women who held more-than-median traditional attitudes at baseline; these women's attitudes shift by 0.11 standard deviations ( $p < .01$ ). Online Appendix Figure A.7 plots gender-attitude distributions at endline and shows that the lack of effect on less-than-median traditional women is not due to ceiling effects. Finally, Online Appendix Table A.13 shows effects on gender attitudes of work experience separately by different work arrangements. The intent-to-treat point estimates are positive for four of the five work arrangements, and the treatment-on-the-treated estimates are not precisely estimated enough to be significantly different from each other.

9. See Online Appendix A.3 for more information on measuring gender attitudes.

(A) Heterogeneity in Job Take-Up by Baseline Gender Attitudes



(B) Treatment Effect of Job Offers on Gender Attitudes

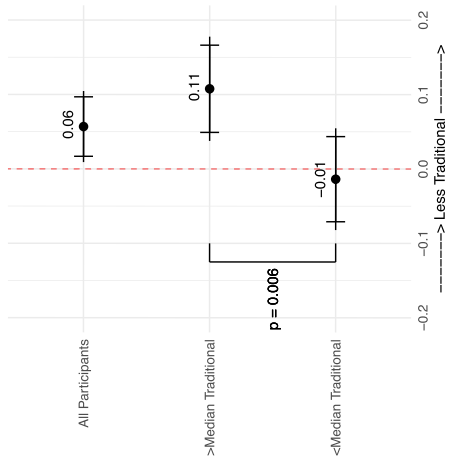


FIGURE IV

Relationship Among Job Flexibility, Gender Attitudes, and Women's Labor Supply

This figure presents evidence that traditional gender attitudes are associated with lower labor supply and mediate the importance of job flexibility (Panel A) and that work experience shifts gender attitudes to become less traditional (Panel B). Gender-attitudes indices are standardized weighted averages of survey questions following [Kling, Liebman, and Katz \(2007\)](#); see [Online Appendix A.3](#) for construction details. Participants are classified as more or less than median traditional according to their baseline index score. Panel A displays job take-up rates across work arrangements, ordered by increasing flexibility, for the 1,250 participants assigned to an R1 job offer. Take-up rates reflect final job offers after randomly assigned upgrades. Panel B plots treatment effects on gender attitudes, pooling all treatment groups against the control group ( $N = 1,525$ ). The x-axis unit is standard deviations of the gender-attitudes index (positive = less traditional). All regressions include LASSO-selected controls and strata fixed effects. Whiskers denote 90% and 95% confidence intervals using heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors.

These results show that job flexibility and work experience affect the same subset of participants: women from more traditional households are those whose labor supply is more responsive to flexibility, and it is these same women whose attitudes change most in response to work experience. Our finding that treatment effects are concentrated among women with more traditional baseline attitudes is consistent with the pathways outlined already: more traditional women have the most room for shifting their attitudes and self-image and likely face the largest internalized and household-level barriers to employment.

*iii. Beliefs Versus Preferences.* [Online Appendix Table A.15](#) and [Online Appendix Figure A.9](#) report treatment effects on the 15 components of the endline gender-attitudes index separately. Thirteen of the components shift toward less traditional attitudes, so the treatment effect reflects broad change across the index. Only two components are individually significant, and they are also the two largest effects: whether a woman would want her daughter to work after marriage, and whether a woman's most important role is to be a good homemaker. Both arguably capture preferences at least as much as factual beliefs. The more belief-oriented components—such as whether men understand money matters better—shift in the same direction but are smaller and not individually significant. We therefore do not take a strong stand on whether the measured shifts operate through updated beliefs about the costs and benefits of working or through changed preferences; the breadth of the pattern across components is consistent with both.

*iv. Correlates of Gender Attitudes.* One concern with our focus on gender attitudes is that attitudes might be confounded with other sources of heterogeneity. [Online Appendix Table A.12](#) presents correlation coefficients between baseline gender attitudes and demographic characteristics. Importantly, covariates that correlate with gender attitudes such as education and having one's own smartphone were included in the causal-forest analysis, yet the gender-attitudes index still emerges with the highest variable-importance score, suggesting that gender attitudes capture meaningful variation in treatment-effect heterogeneity beyond what is explained by correlated observables.

2. *Alternative Mechanisms.* We assess the plausibility of channels other than gender attitudes.

i. *Skills and Signaling.* An initial work experience might help workers gain additional employment by teaching them valuable skills or by signaling to other employers that they have the skills to be good workers. Although these mechanisms could strengthen the gateway-job effect outside this study, our experimental design shuts down this channel. Job offers in R2 are decided randomly with no screening on skill beyond the inclusion criteria for study participation, which required access to a smartphone and literacy in Bangla or Hindi.

ii. *Income Effects.* Income from R1 might affect labor supply decisions in R2 if the household is less financially stressed when the second job offer arrives. However, income effects would push treatment effects in the opposite direction of what we observe: random assignment to a more flexible job would increase income and make it less rather than more likely that women accept a less flexible job in R2. Thus, if present, income effects are dominated by other channels.

iii. *Bargaining Power.* Women's additional income may increase their bargaining weight in household decisions, which could increase labor supply if women are more supportive of themselves working than their husbands are. However, we do not find significant effects on agency as measured by an index aggregating responses about decision-making (see [Online Appendix Figure A.8](#)). This null effect is consistent with prior literature. Unlike studies finding effects on agency from permanent income increases ([Duflo 2003](#); [Field et al. 2021](#)), the income increase in our study was temporary.

iv. *Digital Skills.* R1 work experience involved completing microtasks on a smartphone, which could have increased women's comfort with digital technology. If this skill-building rather than broader updating about employment drove the gateway-job effects, we would expect women to differentially take up digital over non-digital jobs in R2. However, we find no significant difference in take-up ([Online Appendix Table A.20](#)), nor in the gateway effect ([Online Appendix Table A.21](#)) between digital and non-digital R2 jobs, despite the non-digital job (sewing masks, mak-

ing jewelry, and constructing bags) requiring an entirely different skill set. If anything, the gateway effect for non-digital jobs is larger, although the difference is not significant. This suggests that R1 experience shifted women's willingness to work more broadly, rather than simply building task-specific digital skills.

v. *Self-Efficacy.* If initial work experience increases self-efficacy (as found in [McKelway 2025](#)), women might be more willing to take up jobs they consider more challenging, such as an office job, after the first experience with paid work. We do not find treatment effects on women's reported self-efficacy in their ability to use a smartphone for a variety of skills ( $\beta = -2.0\%$ ,  $p = .32$ ), although we cannot rule out effects on self-efficacy in other domains.

vi. *Trust in the Employer and Perceived Safety.* Work experience might affect future labor supply with the same employer if the experience helps build trust in the firm. For example, workers might learn that the employer pays workers on time, or that the managers seem reputable and safe for women to interact with. Treatment-group women may have learned from interactions with staff that the employer is trustworthy, making them more comfortable coming to an office. Increased trust could lead to higher subsequent take-up of less flexible jobs, especially outside-the-home jobs, if women think that it is risky to their safety to go to an office run by an unknown employer. Our gateway-job effect may operate through this channel in addition to gender attitudes, given that existing papers show safety concerns are important to women's labor supply and educational choices in South Asia ([Cheema et al. 2026](#); [Field et al. 2021](#); [Borker 2021](#); [Kapoor and Gade 2024](#); [Tandon 2025](#)). Because all jobs in our experiment come from the same employer, we cannot empirically disentangle this channel from others. If employer trust is important, a key policy implication is that it may not be effective for third parties to provide at-home opportunities that lead to in-person jobs with different employers; this trust mechanism requires the same firm to offer both.

### V.C. *Effects on Well-Being*

In addition to any effects on future labor supply, to assess the welfare effects of increasing the availability of flexible work arrangements, it would be useful to understand how these paid work experiences affect women's well-being. If women are now working for pay and continuing with most of their home production responsibilities, then the work could become a "second shift" even if the women prefer to work for pay (Hochschild and Machung 1989).

Endline survey measures show that work experience has no significant effect on an index of psychological well-being ( $\hat{\beta} = 0.01$ ,  $p = .86$ ), nor on any of the individual index components (see Online Appendix Table A.22). The index is composed of questions in which participants rate how frequently during the intervention period they report (i) sleeping peacefully, (ii) feeling happy, (iii) feeling anxious, and (iv) feeling overwhelmed. Response options are feeling this way never, a few days out of a month, around half the days, more than half the days, or nearly every day.

However, paid work experience does shift women's perceptions of whether their talents and abilities are put to good use. Strikingly, in the control group, more than one in four women report that their potential and talents are not put to use at all. Treatment shifts the entire response distribution to the right: women randomly assigned to receive a job offer are more likely to report that their potential and talents are put to use a little bit, somewhat, or very much ( $p = .02$ , see Figure V).

## VI. EFFECTS OF FLEXIBILITY ON WORKER PERFORMANCE

### VI.A. *Empirical Approach*

We leverage randomly assigned surprise upgrades to separately identify how working from home affects worker performance through treatment effects (effects on inframarginal workers) versus selection effects (changes in worker composition). The identification strategy and estimating equations are described in Section III. Here we provide additional details specific to the performance analysis.

1. *Outcome Measures.* We examine two primary measures of job performance: accuracy and task completion time. Accu-

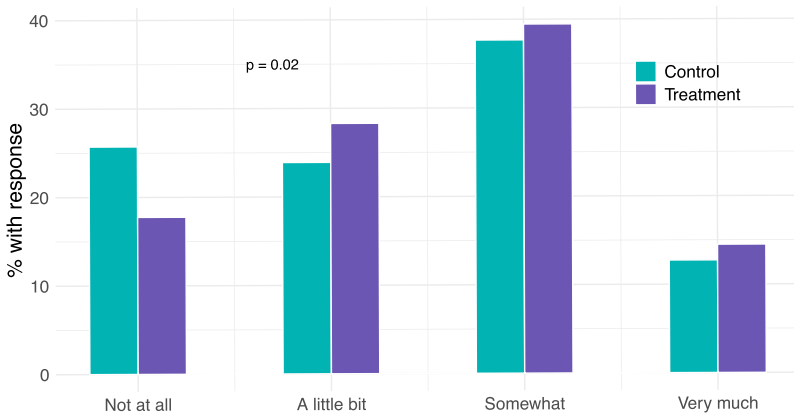


FIGURE V

#### Perception of Whether Talents and Abilities Are Put to Good Use

This figure plots participants' endline survey responses to the question "Do you feel that your full potential and talents are put to good use?"

Response distributions are plotted separately according to treatment assignment. The turquoise (light gray; color version available online) bars represent the share of control group participants with each response, while the purple (dark gray) bars represent the share of treatment group participants with each response. All treatment groups are pooled in this analysis. The reported  $p$ -value comes from a regression which codes participants' responses numerically, with "not at all" as zero, "a little bit" as one, "somewhat" as two, and "very much" as three. The treatment group has a mean score of 1.51, and the control group has a mean score of 1.37. This outcome is regressed on treatment assignment, LASSO-selected controls, and strata fixed effects. Standard errors are heteroskedasticity robust. The results of the regression are presented in [Online Appendix Table A.23](#).

racy is measured on a 0–2 scale by independent validators, where 0 indicates a completely incorrect submission, 1 indicates a partially correct submission, and 2 indicates a fully correct submission meeting all quality standards. Task completion time is measured as seconds elapsed between submission of two consecutive tasks in a work session.

**2. Task-Level Controls.** Because workers complete many tasks over the study period, learning and attrition could confound treatment-effect estimates. To capture these effects, we include these task-level variables in the set of possible controls selected by double post-LASSO: the cumulative number of submissions the worker had made before task  $t$  (which counts repeat attempts at the same task), its quadratic, the cumulative number of unique tasks she had completed, and its quadratic. [Table IV](#) also reports

TABLE IV  
THE TREATMENT EFFECT OF WORK-FROM-HOME ON PERFORMANCE

|                                                     | (1)                                      | (2)                  | (3)                  | (4)                  | (5)                  | (6)                  | (7)                 |
|-----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|---------------------|
|                                                     | Effects of work-from-home on performance |                      |                      |                      |                      |                      |                     |
|                                                     | Panel A: Seconds per task                |                      |                      |                      |                      |                      |                     |
| Final job: <i>Office</i>                            | -6.43***<br>(1.85)                       | -4.39**<br>(1.95)    | -4.65**<br>(1.87)    | -4.49**<br>(1.87)    | -4.56**<br>(1.87)    | -4.45**<br>(1.88)    | -4.40*<br>(2.21)    |
| Final job: <i>Office</i>                            | -4.69***<br>(1.62)                       | -2.61<br>(1.69)      | -2.92*<br>(1.60)     | -2.72*<br>(1.62)     | -2.81*<br>(1.60)     | -3.00*<br>(1.63)     | -1.95<br>(1.64)     |
| Difficult task                                      | 23.3***<br>(1.51)                        | 23.2***<br>(1.52)    | 23.4***<br>(1.52)    | 23.2***<br>(1.52)    | 23.4***<br>(1.52)    | 23.2***<br>(1.64)    |                     |
| Difficult task × Final job: <i>Office</i>           | -5.87**<br>(2.31)                        | -5.88**<br>(2.31)    | -5.88**<br>(2.32)    | -5.88**<br>(2.31)    | -5.89**<br>(2.32)    | -5.08**<br>(2.33)    | -7.78***<br>(2.78)  |
| <i>Office</i> acceptors avg. seconds (simple tasks) | 19.726                                   | 19.726               | 19.726               | 19.726               | 19.726               | 19.726               | 19.726              |
| <i>Office</i> acceptors avg. seconds (all tasks)    | 26.521                                   | 26.521               | 26.521               | 26.521               | 26.521               | 26.521               | 26.521              |
| Observations (tasks)                                | 227,994                                  | 227,994              | 227,994              | 227,994              | 227,994              | 227,994              | 227,994             |
| Observations (workers)                              | 84                                       | 84                   | 84                   | 84                   | 84                   | 84                   | 84                  |
|                                                     | Panel B: Accuracy                        |                      |                      |                      |                      |                      |                     |
| Final job: <i>Office</i>                            | 0.069*<br>(0.036)                        | 0.055*<br>(0.032)    | 0.056*<br>(0.032)    | 0.056*<br>(0.032)    | 0.057*<br>(0.032)    | 0.056*<br>(0.032)    | 0.066*<br>(0.038)   |
| Final job: <i>Office</i>                            | 0.010<br>(0.032)                         | -0.003<br>(0.029)    | -0.002<br>(0.029)    | -0.002<br>(0.029)    | -0.001<br>(0.028)    | 0.003<br>(0.028)     | -0.005<br>(0.033)   |
| Difficult task                                      | -0.280***<br>(0.043)                     | -0.279***<br>(0.043) | -0.280***<br>(0.043) | -0.279***<br>(0.043) | -0.281***<br>(0.043) | -0.304***<br>(0.052) |                     |
| Difficult task × Final job: <i>Office</i>           | 0.195***<br>(0.054)                      | 0.195***<br>(0.054)  | 0.195***<br>(0.054)  | 0.195***<br>(0.054)  | 0.195***<br>(0.054)  | 0.181***<br>(0.053)  | 0.224***<br>(0.048) |

TABLE IV  
CONTINUED

|                                               | Effects of work-from-home on performance |         |         |         |         |         |         |
|-----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|---------|---------|---------|---------|---------|---------|
|                                               | (1)                                      | (2)     | (3)     | (4)     | (5)     | (6)     | (7)     |
| Office acceptors avg. accuracy (simple tasks) | 1.875                                    | 1.875   | 1.875   | 1.875   | 1.875   | 1.875   | 1.875   |
| Office acceptors avg. accuracy (all tasks)    | 1.793                                    | 1.793   | 1.793   | 1.793   | 1.793   | 1.793   | 1.793   |
| Observations (tasks)                          | 231,017                                  | 231,017 | 231,017 | 231,017 | 231,017 | 231,017 | 231,017 |
| Observations (workers)                        | 86                                       | 86      | 86      | 86      | 86      | 86      | 86      |
| Strata fixed effects                          | ✓                                        | ✓       | ✓       | ✓       | ✓       | ✓       | ✓       |
| Lasso selected controls                       | ✓                                        |         |         |         |         |         |         |
| Number previous submissions                   |                                          | ✓       | ✓       |         |         |         |         |
| Number previous submissions squared           |                                          |         | ✓       |         |         |         |         |
| Number previous unique tasks                  |                                          |         |         | ✓       | ✓       |         |         |
| Number previous unique tasks squared          |                                          |         |         |         | ✓       |         |         |
| Task-position fixed effects                   |                                          |         |         |         |         | ✓       |         |
| Task ID fixed effects                         |                                          |         |         |         |         |         | ✓       |

Notes. This table presents the effects of working from home on job performance, in a first specification for all tasks and in a second specification differentially by task difficulty. The first row of each panel corresponds to the first specification, which pools together all tasks. The next three rows of each panel correspond to the second specification, which examines heterogeneous effects by task difficulty. The analysis compares individuals who were randomly chosen for an upgrade from *Office to Home: Fully Flexible* after they accepted *Office* to those who accepted *Office* but were not randomly chosen for an upgrade. This comparison holds worker type constant while measuring differences in performance between *Office* and *Home: Fully Flexible*. In Panel A, the outcome variable is the seconds taken to complete a task. In Panel B, the outcome is the accuracy score assigned to a task. In both panels, the omitted group is individuals who accepted *Office* but were then randomly upgraded to *Home: Fully Flexible*. Panel A includes fewer individuals than Panel B because two workers never completed more than one task in a work session. Final job: *Office* takes value one if the participant was not randomly chosen for an upgrade to *Home: Fully Flexible* and zero otherwise. Difficult task takes value one if the task is one of the three difficult task types (paragraph, backward, open) and zero otherwise. All columns include strata fixed effects. Column (1) includes controls selected by double post-LASSO. Columns (2) and (3) control for the number of submissions the worker made before the task; column (3) also controls for nonlinear effects. Columns (4) and (5) instead control for the number of unique tasks she had completed before the task; column (5) also controls for nonlinear effects. Column (6) includes fixed effects for her position in that sequence, and column (7) a fixed effect for each individual task; task difficulty is absorbed in column (7) and so is not separately reported. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the worker level. \*  $p < .10$ ; \*\*  $p < .05$ ; \*\*\*  $p < .01$ .

specifications with fixed effects for the worker's position in her task sequence and, separately, for each individual task.

*3. Heterogeneity by Task Difficulty.* We examine whether performance effects differ by task complexity. Simple tasks involve reading a sentence displayed on screen, while difficult tasks require more cognitive load: reading sentences backwards, locating specific sentences in paragraphs, or answering open-ended questions. We interact treatment assignment with task difficulty and task type to test whether the productivity effects of working from home are more pronounced for complex tasks requiring sustained concentration.

## VI.B. Results

*1. Treatment Effects of Work-from-Home on Worker Performance.* [Table IV](#) presents estimates of [equation \(4\)](#): the causal effect of work-from-home arrangements on job performance for inframarginal workers. Across a range of specifications that control flexibly for previous tasks attempted and completed, we find robust evidence that working from home significantly reduces worker productivity. Taking column (3) as our reference specification, office-based work reduces task completion time by 18% ( $p = .01$ ) and increases accuracy by 3% ( $p = .08$ ) relative to home-based work. Estimates are stable across columns (2)–(7): completion time falls by 17% to 18% and accuracy rises by 3% to 4%. The completion-time effect is significant at the 5% level in every column, but the task ID specification ( $p = .050$ ) and the accuracy effect are significant at the 10% level throughout. The double post-LASSO specification in column (1) yields larger estimates of 24% and 4%.

We find that the negative productivity effects of home-based work are magnified for more difficult tasks. The second specification in [Table IV](#) interacts the office effect with task difficulty: working from the office reduces completion time for the simplest tasks by 15% ( $p = .07$ ) and for more difficult tasks by 21% ( $p = .01$  for difference with simple tasks). The pattern is present but less pronounced for accuracy: working from the office has no statistically significant effect on accuracy for the simplest tasks but increases accuracy by 12% for the most difficult tasks ( $p < .01$  for the difference relative to simple tasks). [Online Appendix Table A.24](#) breaks these effects down further by individual difficult task

type. We cannot rule out that the upgrade itself generates its own performance effects through changes to morale or feelings of reciprocity with the employers. However, these forces would likely lead us to underestimate the negative effect of working from home on performance.

Our findings largely align with the emerging literature on work-from-home productivity effects, which has so far mostly focused on contexts and populations different from those in our study. In the U.S. context, [Emanuel and Harrington \(2024\)](#) document a 4% reduction in call center workers' productivity when working remotely, with decreases in both call quantity and quality—paralleling our findings on both task completion time (seconds per task) and accuracy dimensions. In India, [Atkin, Schoar, and Shinde \(2023\)](#) find an 18% reduction in productivity among full-time data-entry workers, comparable to our estimated effect size despite our focus on part-time female workers previously outside the labor force. Similarly, [Gibbs, Mengel, and Siemroth \(2023\)](#) find that remote work reduced productivity among high-skilled IT professionals in India by 8%–19%, though their context features collaborative work where communication costs likely play a larger role than in our setting with independent tasks.

2. *Selection Effects: Characterizing Work-from-Home Compli-*  
*ers.* [Table V](#) presents our analysis of selection effects, estimating [equation \(5\)](#) and comparing the performance of inframarginal workers to flexibility compliers working under identical work arrangements. This table scales the difference in performance by the estimated share of flexibility compliers. We present unscaled estimates in [Online Appendix Table A.25](#). Contrary to concerns that offering flexibility might attract lower-productivity workers, we find little evidence of differences in performance between these groups. The point estimates are somewhat suggestive that flexibility compliers complete tasks more slowly—approximately 12.5% slower for simple tasks and 5.8% slower for difficult tasks—but these differences are not statistically distinguishable from zero in five of the six specifications. The exception is column (6), which holds task content constant with a fixed effect for each task: there compliers are 20.7% slower on simple tasks ( $p = .096$ ), while the estimate for difficult tasks (7.2%) remains insignificant. For accuracy outcomes, selection effects are more precisely estimated near zero. A direct comparison that avoids the complier-share adjust-

TABLE V  
CHARACTERIZING WORK-FROM-HOME COMPLIERS: ESTIMATES SCALED BY COMPLIER SHARE

|                                              | (1)                                     | (2)                  | (3)                       | (4)                  | (5)                  | (6)               |
|----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|----------------------|---------------------------|----------------------|----------------------|-------------------|
|                                              | Characterizing work-from-home compliers |                      |                           |                      |                      |                   |
| Work-from-home compliers                     | 2.37<br>(2.80)                          | 1.80<br>(2.63)       | Panel A: Seconds per task |                      |                      |                   |
|                                              |                                         |                      | 2.32<br>(2.78)            | 2.35<br>(2.77)       | 2.44<br>(2.78)       | 3.77<br>(3.06)    |
| Work-from-home compliers                     | 2.47<br>(2.38)                          | 1.85<br>(2.19)       | 2.40<br>(2.34)            | 2.44<br>(2.33)       | 2.39<br>(2.34)       | 4.08*<br>(2.43)   |
| Difficult task                               | 23.2***<br>(1.51)                       | 23.4***<br>(1.52)    | 23.3***<br>(1.52)         | 23.5***<br>(1.52)    | 23.0***<br>(1.61)    |                   |
| Difficult task × Work-from-home-compliers    | 0.036<br>(2.99)                         | 0.088<br>(2.99)      | 0.054<br>(2.98)           | 0.078<br>(2.99)      | 0.333<br>(2.98)      | −1.02<br>(3.62)   |
| Office acceptors avg. seconds (simple tasks) | 19.726                                  | 19.726               | 19.726                    | 19.726               | 19.726               | 19.726            |
| Office acceptors avg. seconds (all tasks)    | 26.521                                  | 26.521               | 26.521                    | 26.521               | 26.521               | 26.521            |
| Observations (tasks)                         | 409,300                                 | 409,300              | 409,300                   | 409,300              | 409,300              | 409,300           |
| Observations (workers)                       | 156                                     | 156                  | 156                       | 156                  | 156                  | 156               |
| Work-from-home-compliers                     | 0.028<br>(0.041)                        | 0.030<br>(0.041)     | Panel B: Accuracy         |                      |                      |                   |
|                                              |                                         |                      | 0.029<br>(0.041)          | 0.029<br>(0.041)     | 0.028<br>(0.041)     | 0.022<br>(0.045)  |
| Work-from-home-compliers                     | 0.018<br>(0.038)                        | 0.020<br>(0.038)     | 0.020<br>(0.039)          | 0.019<br>(0.039)     | 0.019<br>(0.039)     | −0.007<br>(0.039) |
| Difficult task                               | −0.281***<br>(0.043)                    | −0.281***<br>(0.043) | −0.281***<br>(0.043)      | −0.282***<br>(0.043) | −0.291***<br>(0.047) |                   |
| Difficult task × Work-from-home-compliers    | 0.029<br>(0.081)                        | 0.029<br>(0.081)     | 0.029<br>(0.081)          | 0.029<br>(0.081)     | 0.030<br>(0.080)     | 0.096<br>(0.072)  |

TABLE V  
CONTINUED

|                                               | (1)     | (2)     | (3)     | (4)     | (5)     | (6)     |
|-----------------------------------------------|---------|---------|---------|---------|---------|---------|
| Characterizing work-from-home compliers       |         |         |         |         |         |         |
| Office acceptors avg. accuracy (simple tasks) | 1.875   | 1.875   | 1.875   | 1.875   | 1.875   | 1.875   |
| Office acceptors avg. accuracy (all tasks)    | 1.793   | 1.793   | 1.793   | 1.793   | 1.793   | 1.793   |
| Observations (tasks)                          | 416,562 | 416,562 | 416,562 | 416,562 | 416,562 | 416,562 |
| Observations (workers)                        | 158     | 158     | 158     | 158     | 158     | 158     |
| Number previous submissions                   | ✓       | ✓       |         |         |         |         |
| Number previous submissions squared           |         | ✓       |         |         |         |         |
| Number previous unique tasks                  |         |         | ✓       | ✓       |         |         |
| Number previous unique tasks squared          |         |         |         | ✓       |         |         |
| Task-position fixed effects                   |         |         |         |         | ✓       |         |
| Task ID fixed effects                         |         |         |         |         |         | ✓       |

*Notes.* This table characterizes the job performance of work-from-home compliers, in a first specification for all tasks and in a second specification differentially by task difficulty. The first row of each panel corresponds to the first specification, which pools together all tasks. The next three rows of each panel correspond to the second specification, which examines heterogeneous effects by task difficulty. The selection analysis compares individuals initially offered *Home: Fully Flexible* to those who initially accepted *Office* but were then randomly upgraded. This comparison holds work arrangement constant and compares individuals who are marginal to flexibility to those who are not. All estimates and standard errors except the difficult-task mean effect are scaled by the complier share: 47.9% of our sample took up the job when offered the most flexible work arrangement and 14.6% took up the office-based job, so we estimate  $1 - \frac{14.6}{47.9} = 0.695$  as the share of flexible job takers who are flexibility compliers. Unscaled estimates appear in [Online Appendix Table A.25](#). In Panel A, the outcome is seconds taken to complete a task; in Panel B, the outcome is the accuracy score. In both panels, the omitted group is individuals who initially accepted *Office* before being randomly upgraded. Panel A includes fewer individuals than Panel B because two workers never completed more than one task in a work session. Work-from-home compliers equals one if an individual's initially assigned work arrangement was *Home: Fully Flexible* and zero if the initially assigned work arrangement was *Office*. Difficult task equals one if the task is one of the three difficult task types (paragraph, backward, open). All columns include strata fixed effects. Columns (1) and (2) control for the number of submissions the worker had made before the task; column (2) adds nonlinear effects. Columns (3) and (4) instead control for the number of unique tasks she had completed; column (4) adds nonlinear effects. Column (5) includes fixed effects for her position in that sequence, and column (6) includes a fixed effect for each individual task; task difficulty is absorbed in column (6) and so is not separately reported. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the worker level. \*  $p < .10$ , \*\*  $p < .05$ , \*\*\*  $p < .01$ .

ment entirely but with a smaller sample size—the 49 women who declined the office job, were randomly upgraded, and accepted the most flexible job, against the 55 upgraded office accepters—yields the same conclusion ([Online Appendix Table A.26](#)).

Exploring heterogeneity in selection effects by task difficulty, we see that the selection patterns remain statistically insignificant for both simple and difficult tasks, suggesting that flexibility compliers do not possess comparative advantages or disadvantages for particular task types relative to inframarginal workers. [Online Appendix Table A.27](#) presents the selection-results heterogeneity by each task type (simple, backward, paragraph, open). These findings suggest that expanding the labor pool through flexible work arrangements does not come at the cost of reduced worker quality.

#### *VI.C. Mechanisms: Workflow Interruptions and Task-Switching Costs*

What is it about working from home that explains the differences in performance for workers who are situated at the office versus at home? One of the major differences between working at home and working from an office is the possibility for interruptions. At home, other family members may call on participants for their immediate attention, whereas at the office, participants are less likely to be called away from their work. To investigate this channel, we group workers' tasks into work sessions, which are defined as a contiguous segment of tasks in which fewer than 10 minutes passes between consecutive tasks (following [Adams-Prassl et al. 2025](#)).

[Figure VI](#) presents evidence that workflow interruptions are a key mechanism through which flexibility affects productivity. Panel A shows that work sessions are 40% shorter when working from home than at the office (52 fewer tasks on average;  $p < .01$ ; 24% shorter measured in minutes). This pattern is consistent with the hypothesis that workers face a higher arrival rate of interruptions at home from household demands, fragmenting their productive time. These interruptions are consequential for performance because of task-switching costs. We find that there is a “warm-up” period associated with each work session during which workers complete their tasks more slowly and with more mistakes ([Figure VI](#), Panels B and C). Conditional on work session length, initial tasks in a work session are more likely to be

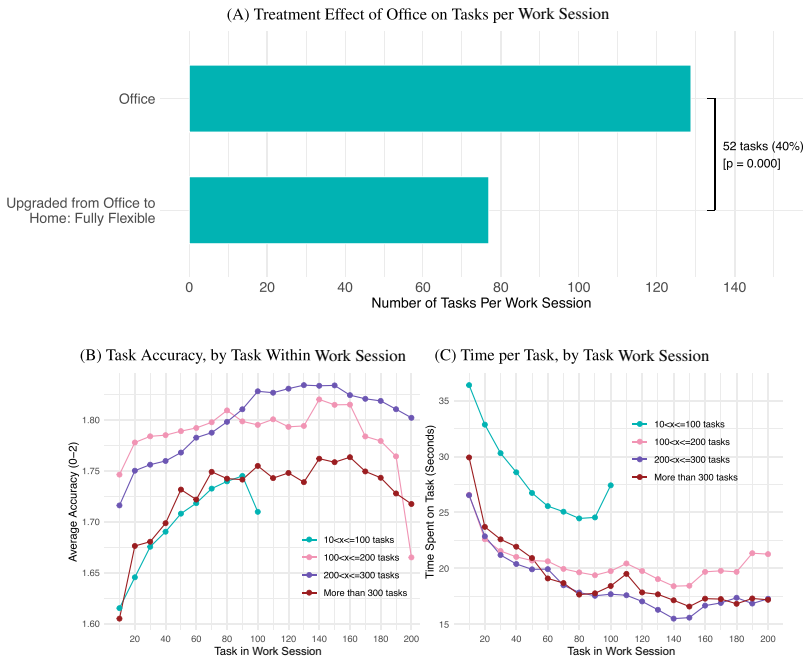


FIGURE VI

## Flow Effects

This figure illustrates how work-session interruptions lead to a decrease in worker performance. Panel A reports the treatment effects of work-from-home on the number of tasks completed per work session. A work session is defined as a continuous segment of time during which a worker submits tasks without taking a break. This subfigure compares the work sessions of workers who accepted an office job and are randomly selected for an upgrade to the most flexible job with those of workers who accept an office job and are not randomly selected for an upgrade. The bracket reports the difference in tasks per work session from home versus office, along with the  $p$ -value from a work session-by-individual-level regression estimating the effect of work-from-home on work-session length (standard errors are clustered at the worker level). Panels B and C describe how accuracy and speed change over the course of a work session. To capture “flow effects” rather than selection into longer versus shorter work sessions, work sessions are grouped according to their number of tasks. The dependent variable is task-level accuracy in Panel B and time spent per task in Panel C. Accuracy is assessed on a scale of 0–2 by an independent team of validators, and time spent per task is measured as the number of seconds that elapse between submission of consecutive tasks within a work session.

completed incorrectly (meaning that participants will not receive full pay, and the output is not useful to the employer). Not only are these tasks more likely to be marked as inaccurate, tasks com-

pleted at the start of a work session also take longer for the worker to complete.

1. *Discussion.* In our piece-rate setting, workers themselves bear most of the efficiency cost through lower earnings, though employers still incur quality control costs for filtering inaccurate submissions. However, if this negative effect of work-from-home on productivity exists even in this context where the worker pays most of the price of lower productivity, then we might expect the negative effect to be exacerbated in salaried jobs in which the employer bears a higher share of the cost. Furthermore, the unpredictable and fragmented work patterns we document might make home-based work particularly problematic for roles requiring synchronous collaboration or rapid response times. Such roles pose a challenge especially for women workers who are expected to be “on call” at home.

#### VI.D. *Costs to the Employer*

Firms’ incentives to offer work-from-home arrangements depend on the trade-off between saving office costs and losing productivity, and importantly, on how wages are structured. Under piece-rate pay, firms save on office costs while workers bear the productivity loss. Under salaried pay with equal wages at home and in-office, work-from-home is more cost-effective at small volumes, while office-based work gains an edge only as a single office fills toward capacity—an advantage that does not compound at larger scales, since each additional office reintroduces the same fixed cost. If firms can set different wages for home versus office, work-from-home is profitable whenever workers’ willingness to pay for flexibility exceeds the productivity loss.

[Online Appendix Figure A.10](#) illustrates this trade-off by plotting firm profitability as a function of total hours of work completed under home-based versus office-based arrangements, holding total hours of work fixed. The figure demonstrates the role of fixed office costs versus lower per hour productivity at home. See [Online Appendix A.4](#) for details and calculations. In our setting, work-from-home can still be attractive overall because it substantially increases labor supply, allowing the firm to scale total hours completed. Finally, work-from-home can also serve as a stepping stone, reducing long-run costs if short-term home-based

experience shifts women's willingness to work outside the home, as shown through the gateway-job analysis in [Section V](#).

## VII. CONCLUSION

Many women who would like to work for pay cannot do so because available jobs are incompatible with their household roles. In a field experiment with 1,670 households in West Bengal, we study the consequences of shaping work arrangements to accommodate expectations of women's domestic responsibilities. We randomly assign women to receive one of five jobs that vary along the ability to (i) flexibly choose work hours, (ii) multitask work with childcare, and (iii) work from home. We estimate the effects of these attributes on job take-up. To separately identify the effects of flexibility on worker composition and job performance, we use randomly assigned surprise job-offer upgrades. Jobs are implemented over the course of one month, and a post-job survey measures effects on the gender attitudes of women. Two to three months after the initial randomized controlled trial, we offer another set of jobs to participants to assess whether work experience increased future interest in work, particularly in less flexible jobs.

We find three sets of results. First, flexible work arrangements are very effective at bringing women who were previously out of the labor force into paid work. Varying different dimensions of job flexibility, we document that the effect of flexibility on labor supply is driven by the ability to multitask (combining work with childcare) and to work from home. These are the deciding factors for many women in whether to work. Second, flexible work arrangements act as a stepping stone to less flexible jobs, including outside-the-home work. Job flexibility makes a large difference to women's labor supply—especially the labor supply of those from more traditional households—and experience with flexible jobs in turn shifts the gender attitudes of these women to be less supportive of traditional household roles. Our results highlight that there is a mutually reinforcing relationship between women's actual employment and gender attitudes that support women's work. Last, we examine the incentives of employers to introduce flexible work arrangements, and we find that work-from-home decreases worker accuracy and increases task completion time. In both cases, a higher arrival rate of interruptions combined with flow effects leads to lower performance when working from home.

One implication of the gateway-jobs finding is that a gradual approach to transitioning women from unpaid home production to market labor, through intermediate stepping stone jobs, could be effective. However, for this approach not to trap women in lower-paying, at-home jobs, the intermediate jobs may need to be temporary so that they do not become an absorbing equilibrium, although the job cannot be so temporary that households do not adjust their attitudes to align with a new reference point (Gulesci et al. 2025). In our study, we only offer women one job at a time; their choice is always to take the job or not have any job at all. That constraint raises a question for future research: if women are given the option to continue working from home indefinitely, is it possible that flexible work arrangements could result in a more gender-segregated labor market? If so, what would help ensure that women do not get “trapped” in jobs that are more flexible but also more precarious or less well paid?

Another policy implication of these findings is that offering flexible work arrangements would likely be an effective strategy for the recruitment and retention of female workers. If firms have work that can be completed from home, then it could be in the firm’s best interest to allow workers to work from home, as this increases the number of potential workers they could access. However, the negative effect of work-from-home on productivity might discourage firms from offering greater job flexibility. That said, it may be possible to offset the negative effect on productivity with lower wages.

Even taking the negative effect on productivity into account, however, there are at least two reasons that work-from-home arrangements may be underprovided. One is that employers may lack the information or skills to offer flexible work arrangements at the efficient level. Employers may underestimate the pool of workers that they miss out on by not offering flexible work arrangements, either in size or skill of the worker population whose labor supply is marginal to flexibility. Employers may also be interested in introducing greater job flexibility, but may not know how to introduce flexible work arrangements without sacrificing worker performance. In addition, employers may not internalize the positive effect of home-based work experience on women’s future labor supply. Better understanding firms’ decisions to offer flexible work arrangements, as well as their willingness to experiment with work-from-home, may be a fruitful area for future re-

search especially in countries with low rates of women's participation in paid work.

### SUPPLEMENTARY MATERIAL

An Online Appendix for this article can be found at *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* online.

### DATA AVAILABILITY

The data and code underlying this article is available in Ho, Jalota, and Karandikar (2026), in the Harvard Dataverse, <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/WWVKAЕ>.

COLUMBIA UNIVERSITY, UNITED STATES

STANFORD UNIVERSITY, UNITED STATES

UNIVERSITY OF BRITISH COLUMBIA, CANADA

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## CALL FOR NOMINATIONS

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